two slow dancers

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24445339.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

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Additional Tags:
Angst, Fluff and Angst, Break Up, Sad, Useless Lesbians, War, Post-War, Gay, Everyone Is Gay, catra regresses, there is so much reference to obscure song lyrics, this is not a proper canon continuation, just a thought experiment, adora loses her shit, wholesome glimbow, double trouble breaks the fourth wall, has some OCs - Freeform, cat planet

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Part 1 of two slow dancers universe

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by orphan_account

Summary

Adora and Catra experience relationship issues, sixth months after the defeat of Horde Prime.

Notes

this is a really sad, angsty, gay fanfiction that will, I hope, tackle everything complex and underlying about Catradora post-season 5. i may have cried while writing this. also heavily inspired by my own associations with the mitski song "two slow dancers"

Nothing Weighs More

Nothing weighs more than the realisation that things are alright.

Except, ponders Adora, maybe Catra after a long day of kingdom management and magic restoration and too much cake, pouring her furry body into a welcoming nighttime embrace. Those two things, Catra and being alright, are mostly the same. The first week post-Horde was a messy and tender one, two girls unleashing 20 years worth of love as fast as their exhausted and broken bodies could handle. Days were hot and sticky, nights longer and stickier, as the two found new and interesting ways to spend every moment attached to each other. Each caress and embrace seemed designed to cross the immense distance that parts of Adora and Catra could see between them, therapy and teary-eyed conversations a secondary language amidst all that physical love. It was often too much for even the other couples in Brightmoon, but Catra and Adora didn't mind being left alone, not if the other was there. They would find new crevices and corners in each other from within their hastily arranged shared bedroom, talk a lot about very little, and construct immutable geometry in the movement of their bodies on dancefloors on distant worlds desperate for She-Ra and a little scared of Adora, or at least this new Adora, all dizzy smiles and late nights. It took time for things to stop being perfect, and for the blanket of pleasant equilibrium to catch Brightmoon and the people within it.

Adora keeps pondering until her lover awakes. It's something she's taken to doing, in the long hours found by a younger, more vigilant girl, the last temporal shadow of a war. Adora likes to think and watch, to force her brain into the wonderfully heavy reality of her bedroom and her friends, and Catra, and Catra's warmth, and she's awake now.

"Hey, Adora."

Catra has probably said that a thousand times, and Adora has loved most every single one, but all the times that Catra has said

it with sleepy, contended acknowledgement are probably the best.

“You ok, darling?”

“Oh! Uhh- yes, sorry, I was just-”

“Staring at me in bed again? Honestly, you’re such a little creep.”

“Little? I’m bigger than you, Catra. But yes, I was staring. You really don’t hate it, or you’d complain more.”

“Maybe I will start complaining more, and then you’ll have to apologise and make that little sad pout and start blushing, and I’ll get to call you cute.”

“I don’t have to do anything, Catra.”

“But you want to.”

“How come you still get to win arguments even after I was the good guy for like, two years?”

“I’m better than you, darling. Didn’t we already talk about this? Now come on, if we sleep in again Glimmer will actually kill us both, not just me this time.”

“Fine.” Gripping each other with assurance, the girls stand up and share another moment of tenderness before remembering they had clothes to put on, duties to carry out and a watchful Queen.

“Why do we have to get up so early all the time? We beat the Horde like six months ago.”

“And not to mention I’ve been using She-Ra to spread magic that whole time. How many planets can there even be?”

“We could always complain to Glimmer. Or take a break. Or just stay here.” Catra can’t help but purr at the thought of spending more intimate time with her girlfriend. Adora had stopped going slightly insane at all of Catra’s animalistic affirmations a long time

ago, but a slight upturn at the corners of her mouth told Catra that the girl, her girl opposite her was currently melting inside anyway.

“I’d like that quite a bit.”

“I know you would, so just let me guide you, Adora.” And with their hands intertwined, Catra feels that most familiar other body in its entirety, letting the music of Adora’s figure speak to her, turning Catra’s movement into the fluidity of a dance. A dance they share in words, in parties and late nights. A dance they had been desperate to share for too many years, a dance they could share freely now. Almost. Because just as Catra’s hands get to searching downwards, just as two lips start to meet and become one, there is a blinding flash and a shrill voice piercing the mixture of silence and happy mewling.

“Catra! Adora! Stop whatever you are doing right now! You are both needed in the war room. A new planet has been spotted by our scouts, one with life. We have to go and check it out!”

“Hey, sparkles, ever heard of privacy?”

“Yea, Glimmer! And will you stop calling it a war room? We’ve been at peace for months now.”

“Sorry, sorry, it’s just we could use She-Ra on this mission-” Catra catches the Queen’s eye with half-serious menace, “She-Ra and her girlfriend. I guess. Are you guys coming?”

Adora, compelled by years of selfless instinct, moves away from clawed hands until Catra audibly protests.

“You don’t have to go and help everyone, darling. Remember? That was the whole point. Just let sparkles and arrow boy handle the alien world, and let me guide you some more, ok?”

“But I have t-” Adora is interrupted in her response by a sloppy kiss and wide, pleading eyes.

“You don’t have to do anything, idiot. It’s like you learned nothing from the time we both nearly died in the Horde ship.”

“We also confessed our love to each other that time. I definitely didn’t forget that.”

“Well if you didn’t, then stay with me.”

“Glimmer, I think I have to stay with my very very needy girlfriend- and she’s gone.”

“Good. She can dance with Bow on some gross alien dancefloor and try and learn a new language in a day while we have fun together here, in this stupid glittery castle that I might be starting to like a lot but don’t ever tell sparkles that.”

“You really are needy. I meant that. You are the neediest girl I’ve ever met.”

“So are you, darling.”

“I’m not! I’m the heroohhhh-" Catra chooses to fight Adora’s hero complex with affection once again, moving her now-claw free fingers downwards and under the grey trousers that Adora insists on wearing from the moment she stirs in the dreary mornings. It would be a sweet little ritual if it didn’t conceal all the nakedness that Catra found so beautiful in her girlfriend, the knowledge that a girl she had loved in burning secrecy and denial for long and painful years was there, open in her eyesight. Exploring Adora with wanton disregard for her wide open eyes and rigid body, Catra uses tail and a free hand to coax her girlfriend into a supple form, letting their desperately close bodies flow with an ineffable rhythm. Catra knows this rhythm, somehow, having wanted it from afar, observed in silence as she tends to do, the way Adora moves and stutters and speaks with her muscular frame, a precise coordination deconstructed when the pressures of Horde life would mount in the quiet hours and Catra yearned so very hard to hold that tear-stricken face and whisper comfort from close up. Adora doesn’t cry much anymore, not that she ever confessed to

doing it in those lonely years, but Catra has taken to letting tears get the better of her. She retracts her attempt at conquering the darker parts of her girlfriend's body, and instead pulls the blonde into a tight embrace, tears pooling on broad, safe shoulders, Catra feeling for once that she is in the safest place in the world.

"Hey, you ok there?" Adora lets worry drip from her words. There was a time when concern and unmasked care would have scared them both, even after the war when the only threat was in each other's minds. They didn't have a proper conversation for weeks, relishing in the language their bodies could speak without fear of betrayal or loss. Even when fighting in the war, they had always felt closest when physically connected.
"Yea I just- I just remembered something from the Horde."

"Catra, he's not in your head anymore, ok? Just keep breathing, remember what Perfuma s-"

"No, not that Horde. Our Horde. The Frightzone."

"Oh." Adora's throat goes dry, her voice shaking over a single syllable.

"I haven't even thought about it in months, not since we last visited Scorpia. And even then… it was just so flowery and all those old spots I used to sit in were falling apart. The spots we used to sit in."

"It's ok to miss it. We had some good times there, I think."

"But that's the thing. What I remembered was- it was horrible, Adora."

"Was it Shadoweaver?" Catra flinches at the name but shakes her head, flicking tears onto awkward parts of her face that Adora instinctively moves to wipe away.

"It was you, darling. You were crying, and I was sitting there and…" Her words trail off before a moment of clarity. "You were so

strong, even then. I saw you crying alone, and I thought: what a fucking horrible place this is."

The two laugh in shaking synchronicity. "It was pretty bad, wasn't it?" Adora stammers through sobs.

"The thing was, I couldn't move. I saw you, in so much pain, more pain than I'd ever seen you show, and I couldn't just go over and help you. Am I- am I awful, Adora? Honestly, after everything, am I an awful person?"

"Catra, you saved the universe. I don't exactly think you can be awful after something lik-"

"I don't care about the universe! I wasn't trying to save it. I was saving you." The two have moved apart somewhere during Catra's outbursts and her tears are now dripping onto nothing.

"I- Catra-"

"Just, let me talk. I need- I need to say so much, to you, to me as well. Just let me." Catra is now yelling through violent sobs, and all Adora can see is that frizzy haired girl from the Frightzone again, angry and alone.

"That's ok, I understand you, Catra. Just come close and don't yell, please? We don't have to do that anymore. I don't want you to do that anymore." Catra nods, quiet and shaking still, moving herself into the glow of Adora's scarred body.

"I've been needing to say a lot for so many months now. It's all so much. You know we never even tried to talk about what happened after the war? We just carried on, tried to live our lives. But I couldn't forget it. At first it was just Horde Prime, what he had done to my head, but then I started seeing all the memories of us again, ones I thought I had buried. I saw all the horrible things I had done, all the times I pushed you away, again and again I put up all these walls, and you were strong still. You smiled at me Adora, you said words I had never heard that made me feel so- so at home. And I wasn't going to mention any of this because it was

dumb and we were happy and you would call me dumb. So I just kept hugging you, hoping the pain would- I don't know, fade? And it did fade, a little. I was numb, honestly. I'd been numb before and it was always one word, always a flash that really made me lose it. This time it was thinking about you, seeing you in the fullest for maybe even the first time, and you were crying. Is that me? Is that what I do? I think- if that's true, and it is, because I thought about it for six months, then now I don't get it." Catra stops to breathe, shaking harder now, Adora feeling a twist in her soul as she sees her lover become so dejected.

"You don't get what?"

And Catra couldn't help but yell.

"Why did you stay, Adora? It's the one thing I can't figure out. What made you stay with me?"

"I- uh,"

"You don't know, do you? You don't know why you've stayed with me for six months. But that's fine. I expected this. I asked you what you wanted before and you never answered. And I thought- I hoped you wanted me, and you just didn't know how to say it. Because that's how I felt."

"Catra, I don't know what crazy ideas you've been dreaming up, I don't know if this is a joke or some kind of magic brainwashing, but whatever it is I'm worried."

"No, I'm fine. There's nothing here for me here, and all I needed to accept that was you to say nothing. To be stuck. Because you spent your whole life protecting me, and you don't know why."

"It's because I love you, Catra." Adora tries to say this with true surety, tries to ignore the tears welling again, tries to ignore her own shock and that twisting in her soul.

"No you don't. You never did. You love everyone, Adora! I'm just the one who happened to get closest. I can't love the world like

you do, and I’m sorry for that. Goodbye.”

“Catra! What?”

“I said, goodbye, Adora. I truly am going to miss you.”

Weight lifted.

Personal Space

Chapter Summary

> Adora struggles with her own thoughts in the aftermath of the breakup. Catra tries to return to old habits and fails.

Chapter Notes

> a plot starts happening, finally. It's still sad but i promise things will eventually get fluffier, at least after a few more chapters of angst.

A week since Adora began the second stretch of her life alone. Throwing herself at every mission, draining She-Ra day in, day out, Adora had tried to forget and live. She had saved more worlds from collapse, been to more parties with banners and cake in her image, and seen more new sunsets than ever before. She was living a hero's life at hyperspeed, and she cried every single night.

A week since Catra vanished, using Melog to dupe the Brightmoon guards and evade Glimmer's hasty search party. She had tried to accept her decision and move forward, stealing where she could and living off the land in the long stretches between Etherian settlements. Villagers and farmers all down the northern Etherian coastline knew her shadow, kept their crops guarded. She was living a runaway's life, and she was cold at nights, not sleeping even after days of running from townsfolk.

"Adora! There's a new planet for you. Our scouts just picked up a signal on the outer rim. There's life there! We can go and h- Adora?" Glimmer pushes her way into Adora's room, her voice echoing from each of the newly sparse and stark walls. Adora is standing, staring at one mirror, her eyes darkened, face stained with tears. "Ok, this? This is not ok. You've been like this for a week now, Adora. You need to talk to someone. I'm always here for you, you know?"

“I’m fine. I’ll go, Glimmer.” In one movement Adora wipes away the remaining tears and summons her sword, an instinctive motion now.

“I really think you should talk this out first. She-Ra is glitching more and more, she seems so weak lately.”

“Then why did you call me just now? You need She-Ra and I can be her, no point fighting it.”

“I didn’t expect to find you like this, Adora. I thought maybe you would have spoken to Perfuma, or at least tried to work it through in your head. But if you want to go, that’s fine, but I’m sending Bow, and Scorpia, with you.”

“What is there to work through? Catra left me. She hates me. She knows I hurt people. So I’ll just prove her wrong. And nice try getting the huggers to come with me, but I’m going alone.”

“No, you are not.” Glimmer tries to put on her Queen Glimmer voice as quickly as possible, a tricky task in front of Adora’s frail, grief-stricken body. “Either you sit here and wallow in silence or you go on that mission with people who actually care about you and you let them care.”

“Fine. But I get my own room, and personal space.”

“I mean of course you get your own room, who else would you have- oh. Well, you can raise the personal space issue with Scorpia, I can’t control her tendencies. The ship leaves in two hours. Bow will get you up to speed. And Adora?”

“Yea?”

“Don’t let this kill you. Catra left you, but that doesn’t make you deserving of self-harm.”

“Whatever. I’ll be She-Ra, spread the magic and we’ll be in and out in a day or so.”

“It’s your magic, remember.”

“She-Ra’s, yea.” Adora walks through Glimmer’s pitying silence and towards her dresser. She had been up for five hours without so much as sorting out her hair. The sunrise has come and gone, filtering through tears instead of blinds, landing on an empty bed instead of a sprawled furry form. Adora reminds herself to ask Glimmer for a single bed again, knowing she will never get round to it. It’s busy being lonely.

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Catra is always on the move. Being free, unconfined by the stark walls of the Horde or the guarded openness of Brightmoon, isn’t so bad after all. Sure, her increasing tendencies towards petty crime have got her in more trouble in one week than in sixth months in that stupid glittery castle, but she can go where she wants, do what she wants. It’s a lot like the Crimson Waste, but without anyone to care about her. Caring was what brought everything crashing down, it’s pointless and illogical, which is why Catra promises herself, silently, to never care about Adora again. Which means not saying, or thinking, her name. It hurt so much to claw back up the mountain, when now she can just drop off and be free, the air buffeting her fur as she falls to a silent death.

She thinks all of this as she runs, always running, always a pitchfork pushing her away. These are the people that Ado- She-Ra cares so much about, these isolated, angry people. Huh. Glimmer called her that once. Not that Catra cares. She tries to excuse that slip-up, telling herself that She-Ra is evil, She-Ra doesn’t care, She-Ra stole everything from her. She’s told herself a lot of things in very little time. She should just keep running.

Weaving her body through a rickety fence, Catra spots her finest prize to date. A whole orchard, food for days, weeks even. Though the field is dreary in the near-nighttime Catra uses as a morning, it is still the right season for fruit, and it stretches out beyond her field of vision. She could stay here, subsist off of someone else’s work- stupid idea. Staying is wrong, it’s illogical

and wrong. Catra is the smart one, Adora is the i- stop it, Catra. Letting herself get set off by these little things is what created this whole mess, so just, stop it. She will have to gather as much as she can carry on Melog and in her backpack, and hope the next village is similarly bountiful. Grabbing her cat companion with careless force, Catra feels the spell cloak her and starts her sneaking. Except, Melog is resisting. They have looked more and more tired each day on the run, smaller and less willing to do as Catra requests. So Melog cannot resist physically for long, against someone who is all too used to being alone and self-sufficient, but they can stop up the flow of magic. "Melog, just let me- Gah! What are you doing?" Melog growls and flashes red, the first time they have shown anger towards Catra since Critis. "Well, if you're going to be stubborn about us surviving, I'll just sneak in myself. Shouldn't be too hard."

"Hey! Who's out there?"

"Quick, Melog, run!" Both of their instincts kick in at once and before Catra has time to think she is a phantom piercing the dusk, leaping the fence and clambering atop Melog as the pair disappear, stomachs empty.

"Figures that the best place we find in months is guarded past dusk, huh? Melog?" The cat is silent. Though their anger has long since abated from the adrenaline rush of escape, Melog is visibly still upset, their collar a deep blue. "Hey, Melog, you know I was just trying to help us. What's the point of invisibility if you only use it to run away?"

You only run away anyway.

"I run away when I have to. I ran away from- you know what, it doesn't matter. No one wants me, so I run."

You said something similar to me before. It was a lie then.

"What would you know? You don't know anything about me."

I know all about lying. Illusions are just practiced lying. You are essentially an illusionist.

"Well, you are an actual illusionist who just refused to use those powers to keep us alive. I think I know which is worse. Now come on, we need to find at least something to eat."

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Adora ponders again, this time alone in the endless sunrise of space. There aren't really a concrete morning and evening to determine hours of rest and vigilance out in that horrible void, so the team sleeps whenever they feel tired. Adora rarely gets more than an hour, awoken by the ghost of her old self that feels closer than ever to her current state, leaping out of bed sweating and exhausted. Somehow, being in the ship with two of the Rebellion's warmest people only makes her feel colder, more alone. She knows they are giving out that love because that's just part of who they are, that it could be anyone being sad. She doesn't deserve that pity, that indiscriminate compassion. Isn't that how Catra sees her? Caring about everyone, even those that have caused more hurt than happiness? Her train of thought is thrown off the rails by the searing pain that Catra's name elicits. It's better just to get on with what passes for a day up here; she was pondering on that horrible morning, after all.

Adora takes time to patch up the ship as she travels its myriad corridors, having gotten fairly good at this kind of rudimentary repair work in the countless missions undertaken since the war. Darla is always going to be a rustbucket, no matter what Entrapta does, but it's easy work and helps Adora focus on nothing, those minute movements and adjustments part of her muscle memory now. Just as her hand moves to solder one last wire, Adora is swept from her steady stance and into a familiar embrace. "Scorpia, could you not? I'm trying to-"

"Shhhhh, this is what you need right now."

“Actually, it isn’t.” Adora makes a decisive twisting motion that shocks Scorpia into letting her go, and with a wobble she is back on two feet. “I know Glimmer put you up to all these hugs, but you really can stop now.”

“Wait, I can?” Not the response Adora was expecting at all. Scorpia is always up for hugs, at least that’s what six months of elated affection seemed to suggest.

“What do you mean?”

“Well, it’s just- Look, Catra left for a reason, and even though I’m your friend, and Glimmer kinda ordered me to be all, well, Scorpia-like to you, I need to know if you hurt Catra, because that girl has been through so much and if you even-” Adora flinches with every word, but forces out a response.

“I really, uh- I really don’t want to talk about it. But, no, I didn’t hurt Catra, or at least I didn’t try to. She chose to leave. She- she wanted to leave.” She stumbles at the last part, choking every syllable out into the infinite corridor.

“Oh. Well, maybe Glimmer was right, you do need a hug or two.”

“Just make it quick, I’m not in the mood for physical contact right now.”

“I can always be a listener, if you want to talk?”

“No. I just- I need to process this myself. That’s for the better. That’ll help. Just don’t tell Glimmer when we get back, ok?”

“If that’s what you feel you need Adora, I won’t stand in your way. Just remember I’m here.”

“Sure.” Adora decides to head back to her room. If she can just sleep it all away, she might be able to summon She-Ra when they arrive. She always benefited from a clear head. No distractions.

When Adora drifts away into a restless sleep, she finds herself in a dark room, almost too dark. Its dimensions and shape are unclear, but rotating her head Adora can make one thing out. Shadoweaver.

You failed, Adora. You were meant to keep her in line. Now she's gone, free to cause mayhem and destruction all over Etheria. You were keeping her docile. It almost worked, I have to commend the strategy.

You don't know a thing about me and Catra, you never did!

Oh, but look how much pain she causes you.

Adora's perspective lurches and suddenly she is seeing herself, younger, face lined with scratches and tear stains. Catra, or a younger Catra, can be heard in the distance.

I will never apologise! You just want to leave me! I hate you!

Shadoweaver's face emerges from the Frightzone gloom.

Why do you keep crawling back to her, Adora? Don't you ever listen to her?

That's not the real Catra. That- she would never mean something like that. You made her think that!

You really can't keep blaming me. At some point, you have to fix yourself. I'm gone, Adora, leave me be.

You came here! You're in my dream and I don't know why!

I had to show you the truth first, before you could start to heal.

Shadoweaver vanishes and Catra turns around, her teary eyes visible for only a split second before her face morphs into Glimmer's, still teary eyed and still staring Adora down.

You let my mother die, Adora. You couldn't sacrifice yourself when it really mattered. You hurt people.

Stop! Stop showing me this!

But you've seen it all before. Why does it still hurt, Adora?

Because- why does everyone always ask me the questions? Why am I always choosing, or having to do something? It's always a sacrifice, or a request, or a fight. Just- just leave me alone!

But you need all these people. They need you. At one time, I needed you.

I don't want to be needed! I don't want to fight.

That's living, Adora. Make your choices, but they will always cause you pain. It's for you to decide whether that pain is worth it.

I don't know.

Then figure it out. You were always a smart girl.

Glimmer's face vanishes. The Frightzone vanishes. Shadoweaver's voice echoes into eternity, and then there is a blinding flash. Adora wakes up, with Bow in the doorway waiting restlessly.

"C'mon Adora, we have a planet to help."

She steps out into an alien sunrise, the most glorious morning she has ever seen. And standing, staring wide eyed at Adora, greeting her with open arms, is Catra. Or at least, it looks like Catra. Fluffy ears, mobile tail, devilish grin. It should be Catra, but it isn't. Adora stumbles, caught by the hurried arrival of Bow and Scorpia.

"Is this a planet… of cat people?" Bow looks almost as shocked as Adora.

"Welcome, visitors! We invite you humbly onto our world, as guests of the Felin Empire."

“The Felin- excuse me, are you- are you all…” Adora trails off.

“What my friend is trying to say is that we are grateful for your hospitality, and look forward to spreading our magic to your empire.” Bow with a hurried save. Adora has gone pale, wide eyed and barely conscious, her head spinning too fast to comprehend anything. All she can think is that the universe must really hate her today.

Familar Faces

Chapter Summary

> Adora finds herself reminded of Catra at every turn, even as her mission turns sour. Catra sees both success, and the emergence of a new rival.

Chapter Notes

> woah some things are really starting to happen now yea. don't worry, more catradora interactions will come soon, but there is a plot to contend with as always

“Scorpia, we have got to do something about Adora. She’s stayed in her room the whole time we’ve been here, she’s not eating any of the food we bring her, and She-Ra definitely isn’t making an appearance any time soon.” Bow is panicking; Scorpia hasn’t known this endlessly compassionate, organised man for very long, not in a friendly capacity anyway, but she can sense that her mission companion is feeling the brunt of the stress.

“Bow, I think you might just have to talk to her.”

“But didn’t you say she shut you down?”

“Yeah, but I’m not exactly her best friend. Me and Adora don’t really get along; I’ve tried hugs and karaoke and emotional support, which usually works on everyone, but she’s just- I know you guys are close, and as much as I do want to help her, I know that you’ll do a much better job.”

“But she was really dismissive of Glimmer, too. Which- well, it’s not unlike Adora to have issues with Glimmer, just I thought we had dealt with all that and now- now it’s all going wrong!”

“Woah! Woah, it’s ok Bow. Sure, Adora is in a pretty bad place right now, and even taking it out on her friends. I had a similar experience back in the Horde, and do you know what I did?”

“Run away?”

“Well- yes, ok, I did run away but you know what I did first? I did everything in my power to support the person who seemed desperate to push me away, and you know what? We had some great times. And even when I had run away and I thought all was lost, the universe intervened and said ‘Hey, you know what Scorpia? You are a great friend, and a great person, and Catra is gonna come back to you and you guys can hug and stay up all night together and it’ll all be great.’ The world will reward you for unconditional kindness, Bow. At least, that’s what I want to believe.”

“Thank you, Scorpia. Even if you don’t mean it for Adora, I think you are a great friend, to everyone. There might be some jealousy with you involving her but you don’t let that stop you and that’s great. Ok, I’m off to be a good friend too, have fun at the next party!”

“Hey, Bow, what do you mean jealous- he’s gone. Huh. Maybe I am? No, that doesn’t sound right.”

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Catra is tired. She has barely slept in what feels like forever, using the nighttime for hunting and travelling, the daytime for endlessly disturbed rest and eating what little food she can scavenge. Having stolen a map from a nearby town, she knows roughly where to head to reach the Crimson Waste, a place devoid of love and care where she can bully people into staying with her, and discard them as she pleases. It’s a familiar desire, hardwired into the dark parts of her brain. Though her brain is running on empty, she spots a village in the distance, unguarded and ripe for the looting. “Come on, Melog. This one’s gonna be easy.”

Darting between trees and over streams, scrambling up the steep hill that the villagers presumed would keep them safe, Catra finds herself at the outskirts. Her and Melog take up a hiding place between two rickety wooden houses, an imperfect vantage point

but a safe one. It is still early evening, the sun low and searingly bright, shielding the town from Catra's wondering eyes. They nap a short while, unnoticed by this docile scattering of defenceless Etherians. When Catra jolts awake, her body rejecting deep sleep, it is nearly night and the village is silent. She quells a pang of guilt instilled by the pre-nap memory of a tiny child dropping their She-Ra doll in the dirt, a parent moving over to rescue it with a tender smile. These were people, and people- people never did anything for Catra. At least, they hurt her more than they helped her. Ignore the sob stories and get on with living. Overthinking instead of stealing. In her guilty reverie, Melog has snuck off in the direction of a bakery, the sweet smells enough to override their previous refusals, and Catra can only growl and follow her cat's shimmering shape in the dusk.

The bakery is dark, the outlines of its interior fading into the blackness. Even with Catra's sharp vision, the prize inside is difficult to make out, and she has to perouse about the room with care and grace before the door to the storage room emerges in her field of view. Prying it open, creaking and scratching sounds impossibly loud in her ears, the minute movements of her clawed feet against the hard stone floor, Catra spies the bounty in one corner of the room, thankfully illuminated by the light of the emerging moon. Rushing in with Melog at her side, Catra grabs as much bread and pastry as she can throw into her backpack, her chest tightening with all the noise, so hungry and uncaring in her movements. Melog is eating straight from the pantry shelves, desperate for a hearty meal, the illusion flickering as they become overwhelmed with filling their stomach. In a moment of lucidity, Catra realises they have overstayed their welcome, and finishes shoving food into the strained backpack before grabbing Melog and running out and into the night air without care except for the growling in her belly. Finding another tucked away alley, she sits down to eat.

The town is empty. It has been for hours, as Catra has eaten and napped, trying not to drain her newly acquired supplies as she drifts awake from every doze feeling as hungry as before. Melog has lay contentedly in the glare of the moonlight for most of the

night, already looking more like their former self. A breeze flows in from the distant mountains and tousles Catra's scruffy hair and unkempt body fur. Adora used to do that, moving her hands gently through the parts of Catra's body where fur grows naturally longer, tufts that she had always hated until Adora's gentle touch. The greyish hair that grew out from behind her cheek, hair that was now growing back out without Adora there to cut and maintain it. Catra would always demand that the tufts there be cut, wanting some semblance of control in the aftermath of the war, Adora complying reluctantly. Adora helped her be neat and tidy, to look good as the second face of the Rebellion. Adora helped her. Adora- there is a rustling nearby. Catra grabs Melog as the danger pulls her from that horrible mindless reverie, the blushing fading from her face while the illusion washes over her. Someone is out there: the rustling is slight and regular, the sounds of someone moving deliberately through the shrubbery at the fringes of the village. Catra hunts and tracks, catching an unfamiliar scent in the air. Pulling Melog down behind the well at the centre of the village, Catra decides to stake out this mysterious inhabitant of the nighttime. Or at least, she intends to. A flash of golden hair, a red gemstone flying past Catra's wide eyes, and a cockish grunt that snaps her head round to see something, someone that nearly knocks her out on the spot.

It's not Adora, more like a kid in a bad costume, but Catra can't help but let the sight affect her.

"Hey, you! I've been watching you since reports emerged you were wreaking havoc up the coastline. It seems you finally stuck around in one place for long enough, Catra."

"Firstly, how do you know my name? And secondly, who are you? I don't need some stuck up kid in a costume stopping me from surviving, so just answer me and get out of my way. For your own sake." Catra alternates between shocked confusion at this familiar outfit, and wanting to laugh away this little kid playing hero.

"I'm He-Man! Ally of She-Ra and defender of Etheria. This village is the latest in a long line to have been terrorised by you, the evil

Catra, Horde scum and enemy of She-Ra. As she is currently out of action, it is my duty to take you down!”

“I may have stolen here and there, but I’m no Horde scum, and I don’t think I’m an enemy of She-Ra. Did you not hear about us saving the universe? Did that part of history class not interest you enough?” Catra flinches every time at the word ‘She-Ra’, even when spitting it out of her own mouth.

“Pshhhh, gimme a break! You? Saved the universe? You are the sworn enemy of all that is good in Etheria, now taste my justice!” He-Man charges and before he even reaches Catra she has darted away into the shadows.

“I’ve nearly taken over this planet while fighting an alliance of angry Princesses, and you think you can beat me with bad boxing?”

“I don’t need to. The town is waking up, Catra. I was pretty loud, after all.”

“God, you are pathetic.” Catra pre-plans her escape route, out round the back of the village, but decides to stay and mock this He-Man a little longer.

“I’m fighting for innocent people. You have spent the last few weeks scavenging for scraps and murmuring Adora’s name everywhere you go, which to me sounds a lot closer to pathetic. She must have really done a number on you.”

“Adora didn’t do anything to me. Well- I don’t have to explain myself to you, creep. Leave me alone.”

“Return what you stole and I’ll stop following you.”

“Not gonna happen, kid.” And with far too much resentment now burning in her heart for a child with an attitude, Catra vanishes, Melog’s shimmering red mane fading like sunlight.

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“Hey, Adora?” Throwing off her covers, Adora leaps to her feet at the familiarity of those words, but it is only the soft silhouette of Bow in her doorway.

“Uh- hi, Bow. I was just-”

“It’s ok. I probably shouldn’t have used those exact words. I just, uh- wanted to have a talk about stuff, normal stuff. You know, it’s not healthy to be holed up in your room all day. You could stand to at least say hi to me and Scorpia.”

“Scorpia doesn’t care! She doesn’t even like me. God, how bad do I have to be for Scorpia to dislike me! She likes everyone. I’m really awful, aren’t I, Bow?”

“I’ll be honest, I think Scorpia was more jealous than anything. And no, you aren’t awful, Adora. You’ve saved me more times than I can count.”

“Jealous? Why would she… that doesn’t matter. It’s not that I haven’t tried to help people, but I do it for the wrong reasons. I’m selfish, and I turn away people who actually care about me, and then I try to help everyone because I’m too scared to tell the people I do love that I’m sorry for everything.”

“If you really were helping people for the wrong reasons, you wouldn’t be worrying about all this. You have a good heart, Adora. Trust it for once. And get out of this room, it smells… funky.”

“That’s- that’s a really good point actually. I’ll try, at least. To trust it. And I can leave this room, sure, but how can I go outside? Everyone out there reminds me-”

“So what?”

“I’m sorry?”

“So what if we’re on the planet where your ex came from? They aren’t her, and you are the strongest, bravest person in the universe, and you can help them like you helped everyone else!”

“I can’t! She-Ra is gone!”

“She’s what?”

Adora shakes before responding, feeling so small in Bow’s shadow. “She-Ra, she- I don’t feel her anymore. I’ve been staying in this room a lot trying to feel her presence without any distractions, but ever since we landed everything has just- it threw me off and now I just can’t sense her at all.”

“Is it the same as when you broke the sword?”

“No, that felt more like a release of all the bad parts of She-Ra. Even if I didn’t realise it, she was still there. But now-”

“I know this stuff is probably hard to explain, but what does She-Ra actually… feel like?”

“She’s like- like this bright, bright warmth. Having her presence makes me feel safer and more assured, like- like she’s supporting me, even when I’m not her.”

“That sounds amazing.”

“It is- I mean it was, but that warmth… it’s just faded, Bow. I haven’t felt like this since- since before I met Catra.”

“That’s it!”

“Uh- that’s what, Bow? That wasn’t exactly a eureka moment.”

“But it was! That warmth you feel, it’s love! If the only time you’ve felt like this is before you even left the Horde, then it can’t just be some sort of magic She-Ra feeling. It has to be something deeper, and if you say it’s faded now, and that it only began after you met Catra, then… then you must have finally accepted Catra is- oh, Adora, I’m so sorry…”

Bow rushes in for an embrace, letting Adora’s gentle sobbing that had begun during his theorising shake his body gently. “It’s ok, I

know you're feeling horrible about this whole thing, and I'm not gonna let you go and I'm not gonna leave your side until you are feeling better. Is that ok?"

Through tears, Adora squeezes out a "yes."

They sit in silence for a while, Adora wiping away stray tears as she leans on the one person who she knows she can depend on.

"You are too good at being my friend, Bow."

"I wouldn't have it any other way, Adora. Now, how about some cake? Scorpia just sent me a message on the tracker pad saying she can bring back some."

"I wouldn't mind going out and trying the food myself. It smelt really good from in here." Bow's gentle face is overrun with a smile, as he practically scoops up Adora from her bed and into the bright light of the open ship corridors. Adora marvels at how most of the damage has been fixed during her days locked away, before being dragged out by a still-beaming Bow into the world.

The sun on Ariabos (Bow tells her that is what the locals call their planet) seems to be bright all the time. It pours over the ornate dinner table, the friendly visages of assorted guests and the rolling hills beyond, lending this verdant field a warm, washed out ambience. Though her eyes are still adjusting, Adora can make out the most important members of this gathering, from their kaleidoscopic outfits and expectant gazes in her direction. Bow nudges her and murmurs quietly: "Are you gonna introduce yourself, or-"

"Oh, yeah." Adora adopts her strongest, most heroic voice, but to her it still sounds frail. "Hello, people of Ariabos. My name is Adora, but most of you will know me as She-Ra, princess of power. Me and my friends have traveled to your planet after receiving a signal some weeks ago, and we hope we can spread our magic to your world and fix any damage Horde Prime may have caused. As you may have noticed, I was not available until

now, due to some-" Adora glances over at Bow for some help, faltering in the first moment of vulnerability. Thankfully, he takes up the mantle, "some technical difficulties involving the ship and She-Ra. It's like a fancy interconnected magic issue, sort of, She-Ra is like very magical and spiritual and-" Adora takes back the mantle: "And now the issue has been resolved. She-Ra is all fine and ready to spread magic to your world."

Bow grimaces at Adora's overconfident rescue. She can't have already felt She-Ra again, not after seeing so many cat people smiling at her, unknowing.

"Well, Adora, it is wonderful to finally meet you. We have tried to make our home as hospitable as possible for such exalted guests as yourselves, and after dinner I'm sure we can begin highly productive negotiations."

"Negotiations?" Bow and Adora speak almost in unison, the issues with magic pushed to the back of their minds.

"Oh, excuse me. I did not mean to jump to business so quickly, but I am sure you are both now confused, so I will explain. The Felin Empire has no need for your magic: we were untouched by the Horde, and our land is thriving, as you can see. Rather than let our planet become another part of Etheria's magical coalition, we will remain an independent galactic entity and create our own empire in space. Of course, we do not seek any antagonism with Etheria or its conquests, and so the subject of our negotiations will be establishing the area of space in which our empire can expand peacefully. But that is of course a matter for a different time, and different people. Maybe your Queen Glimmer would like to hear of our ideas?"

"You- you don't want our magic?"

"Well of course not! Our planet sustained no damage from either the Horde or what you call the First Ones, so why would we exchange our freedom for She-Ra to fix an issue that is simply not present?"

Adora is indignant, thrown completely off course by this sudden refusal. “The planets under our control are free! When we leave them, they can do what they want. It’s a galactic recovery mission, not some power ploy.”

“All empires have a desire for land and power. Whether your position as the unquestionable hero She-Ra allows you to see it or not, those planets and their remaining populations have remained loyal to your cause. Etheria is not just She-Ra: our scouts have noticed multiple examples of agents of Queen Glimmer visiting conquered planets to trade for resources, establish Etherian diplomats, and even bring settlers from your homeworld to supplement existing communities.”

“That’s- that’s not true!”

“Adora, it is.” Bow’s head hangs heavy before his friend, knowing that his and Glimmer’s deliberate secret is now blown forever.

“Bow, you- you never told me. How could you… our mission was always to set these planets on the right path and then let them take it, not just become another Horde!”

“Look, when Glimmer suggested it to me, I was shocked and angry too. But we can do a better job than anyone has done before! You heard the Felin Empress, we’ve only been benevolent.”

“It doesn’t matter what we are doing with the planets we visit, what matters is that we are essentially taking them over.”

“It’s mutual!”

“It’s only mutual because we saved them with magic! What happens if in 10 years they get unhappy with our rule and try to get rid of us? Do we just let them, and watch them fall apart without our help? Or do we crush that uprising, which basically makes us another Horde, just with sparkles and magic?”

“I can see you two are having some- disagreements, so I will postpone our dinner and let you two sort this out for yourselves before returning to Ariabos.”

Armed guards appear from nowhere, taking Adora and Bow by the arms with a surprising amount of force. “We will not concern ourselves with Etherian diplomacy. Ariabos is a place of singular peace and order, and we will be willing to talk to Etheria when it reflects those same values. Until then, may our two empires exist in harmony without the need for failed talks such as these. I wish you a safe journey, Bow and Adora.”

Back on the ship, now heading away from the planet that Adora had hoped would be a ray of hope, the three friends are awfully silent. It’s been a long, long day, and Bow and Scorpia are tired. Adora stays awake for most of their journey home. She is tired from the moment they leave to the moment they set down in Brightmoon, almost as tired as she is angry.

On the other side of what is considered Brightmoon territory after the fall of the old Horde, Catra is angrier.

Alei

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer travels to northern Ariabos for negotiation and makes a few unexpected friends.

Chapter Notes

> wooooooo glimmer gets a chapter. honestly glimmer is such an interesting character and i'm obsessed with the idea that she becomes more thoughtful and level-headed post-war while still keeping her stubborn streak. chapter 5 will be sillier, don't worry

Two nights since Catra's first truly successful break-in, since He-Man appeared, and she hasn't slept at all.

"Who does that brat think he is? Ordering me around, waking up that whole town, for what? Some sort of power fantasy? And now he's probably following me. Or, scratch that, he's been following me this whole time! Ugh, creepy little shit. I should get rid of him.

You could have done so at any time.

"Yeah, obviously. He barely knows how to punch."

So why didn't you?

"I don't know! I guess- Seeing him in those clothes, even if it was just a bad costume-" Catra hears a rustling in the bushes, but spins around to find nothing. "It felt like back when I was fighting Adora and she- and I could never properly hurt her. It just felt- gah! Why are you so good at making me have horrible thoughts?"

I don't make you do anything. You just miss her.

"I do not! Shut up! Adora doesn't want me. For real, this time."

Your denial will cause you pain. It already has.

"What causes me pain is going hungry all the time because my magic cat prefers to ask me intrusive questions rather than help us both stay alive. Now come on, we have to keep moving."

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Glimmer often finds herself at her bedroom window when alone. Stuck in the kingdom she loves, sharing the brunt of day-to-day management with her tireless father, she has plenty of time for self reflection. Though she has politely declined to attend Perfuma's morning meditation, these quiet moments give her space in the same way that Scorpia and Catra had described. The sun in Brightmoon always seems warmer, especially in the shifting obscurity of dawn or dusk. There is something about the way it dances on the hilltops and seeps through rose-tinted glass, a silken blanket in quiet hours, that whisper to Glimmer the ineffable secret of a safe home. Coming through the corridors, echoing through her reverie, is the voice of her father.

"I'm taking a visit to Mysticor, should be back in a week or so. Keep the kingdom running in my absence! Love you, darling."

Glimmer smiles, knowing she will miss her father, willing to let him be missed. "Ok dad, see you when you get back. Love you too!"

No time anymore. Glimmer vanishes in a cloud of glitter dust and appears in her throne room to be greeted with the downcast faces of her two closest friends. They have approached her empty throne in the manner befitting of visitors or subjects, heads down, resting on one knee.

"Adora! Bow! You two look… alive. How was the visit to Ariabos?" Glimmer tries to sound welcoming, like the old friend she hopes they see her as, not the Queen.

"Not great. The people of Ariabos are friendly enough, sure, but their empress is- well she's very strict and wants to expand into

interstellar territory under the name of the Felin Empire, and not to mention she rejected Adora's magic."

"That's not important right now, Bow. What is important, is a little something I found out while on Ariabos about how you have both been taking over defenceless planets in the name of Etheria. You promised me after we began these missions that we would never let someone like Horde Prime rise to power, and that we would do that by allowing planets freedom and the ability to choose their own paths. How is colonisation freedom?"

"Adora, you have to understand-"

"No, I understand perfectly well. The Felin Empress was very, very clear in describing the steps you have taken on other worlds to bring them under your control. And to think I ran missions for you, used She-Ra every day for months, serving a regime I didn't know existed. It's like I'm back in the Horde."

"How dare you! Our diplomatic outreach is nothing like the Horde. Some of the planets we visited needed our further support, and some of our people needed space to settle. It's mutually beneficial!"

"It's an empire! The Etherian Empire. That can't be right."

"Well, you don't have to help it, if you don't want to. But we need you, Adora. The universe needs you. Don't deny all those worlds help because you have a moral compass."

"I won't serve an empire. I will spread magic, on my terms, and leave the people of the planets I help to be free. It's the least I can do. I nearly destroyed everything twice, and I do not get to repay that debt by advertising the next galactic regime. I'll be in my room if you want to talk."

Adora gets up with as much strength and grace as she can muster, turning away from her friends before they can catch a glint of the tear in her right eye. Bow breaks from his position of respect, watching his friend leave.

“I’m worried about her, Glimmer. First Catra and now- now she knows. We shouldn’t have kept it secret.”

“You saw her reaction, it would have been better if she never found out.”

“What about in 10, 15 years if we start having to quell protests, establish order? You know, government stuff? She would have found out then.”

“That won’t happen, Bow! We’ll- we will listen to any protests, meet their demands, and only create order when the people of other planets want it.”

“I’m still worried about this whole thing. Us? Ruling an empire? It feels wrong, somehow.”

“I know you had your doubts, but we’re doing great so far! We’re the best friend squad, remember? We’ve got this.”

“It’s not the best friend squad without Adora. You know what, I’m gonna go talk to her. Again.”

“And I’m gonna go to Ariabos and see what all the fuss is about.”

“Alone? That seems- unsafe.”

“The Felin Empress can’t be that scary if she’s seeking our permission to go into space. And besides, I can handle myself. You are such a worrywort, Bow!”

“Fine. Just- be careful, ok? Space still freaks me out, even after all these missions.”

“I’ll be fine, Bow! You know, it’s cute that you worry so much.”

“It is?”

“Well, it’s annoying as well, but it makes me feel cared about.”

“You’re gonna make me blush!”

“Hahaha, you big softie. A kiss before I depart, Sir Bow of Brightmoon?” Glimmer was never very good at sounding royal and proper.

“Of course, your royal excellence, her majesty Queen Glimmer.” Luckily, neither was Bow. And with a tight embrace and Bow’s obligation to his girlfriend’s request still fresh in her mind, Glimmer makes her way onto Darla, leaving the kingdom in the hands of her most responsible friend, hoping he can keep the ship sailing and mend wounds in the way he has done for what feels like forever.

With Ariabos now visible through Darla’s front facing window, specially coated to keep out the worst of the sun, Glimmer takes to aimless thought again. The sunlight up here is harsher, forcing its way into the corridors and crevices of the ship whenever a star is nearby. There is no love to be found in this vast expanse, no journey to be made without sacrifice. It’s eerie, and always too cold, in spite of those endless angled sunbeams turning the ancient ship into fragments. She can’t help but feel alone. Darla’s voice is still sudden and only barely familiar, snapping her back to the semi-reality adopted for simplicity’s sake by most everyone. “Arriving on Ariabos in 30 Etherian minutes. All necessary maintenance chores have been completed. You will find your ceremonial outfit is ready for you at the door.”

“That’s fine, thank you. I’d rather stay in these clothes. Far comfier.”

“I do not understand what ‘comfier’ is, but this will not significantly alter procedure.”

“You’ve never felt comfort?”

“I am an artificial intelligence designed to manage and control interstellar craft number 33065. I do not have any perception of many human sensations, including comfort.”

“Well, it’s like- like being safe, and content. No danger, or worry, or pain. It feels kinda heavy, I guess. A good heavy.”

“My human safety protocol tells me that being under excess physical pressure can cause intense pain and damage. Do you need assistance with removing this comfort, Queen Glimmer?”

“No, that’s fine, Darla. And could you just call me Glimmer?”

“This will not significantly alter procedure. And I can assume it will make you feel ‘comfier’?”

“Yes- yes it will. Thank you, Darla.”

“Approaching Ariabos for landing in 30 Etherian seconds.”

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It’s a cold midday in the northern stretch of Ariabos’ main landmass. Darla touches down in a valley surrounded by ice-capped mountains, the scenery a stark and undeniably gorgeous painting. Glimmer steps out onto the frost-tipped grass, noticing locals in the distance near a small coppice of enormous trees, their deep greens and the piercing white of the snow fighting for dominance in their small portion of this vast landscape.

They approach, tails and ears prominent through what looks like warm formal get-up, and Glimmer realises part of why Adora was so forlorn after the mission. Though Catra was never close to her, not for very long at least, it is still unsettling to see others with her features so far from home.

“Welcome, Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon! It is an honour to finally meet you. We have prepared a small dance and dinner as a token of our goodwill towards the Etherian Empire. And as for myself, my name is Meora, and I am a representative of the Felin Empire. Our empress was unfortunately unable to make it up north at such short notice, but I work only in her interests and will be carrying out initial negotiations prior to the dance. My companion here is Alei, and she will accompany you to your

quarters and keep notes on the conference. Is that everything, Alei?" Meora, a slender but imposing figure, turns to Alei, the shorter girl holding a shakily reserved expression and closed-in stance. She nods hurriedly and gestures to Glimmer to follow her. Meora watches them as they travel down the valley, her gaze narrow.

"So, Alei, what's it like on Ariabos? The scenery is certainly beautiful."

"Good. The Empire treats us well."

"Meora seemed… nice. Are you guys close?"

"Meora is- she is a faithful agent of the Empire. She treats me well." Glimmer swears she sees blushing through the thick fur on Alei's face.

"Awwww, I can tell you like her!"

"I serve in her interests. She tells me I am a good assistant. She praises me. She-"

"You know, it's ok to love, right? Love shouldn't be something to fear. Besides, you guys are cute, even if Meora seems a bit cold."

"Your room is in that chalet up by the river. If you need anything, I will be in the town house down the road."

"Thank you, Alei. You seem really nice. If you wanna talk during the dance, I would be happy to meet you there."

"No, thank you. It is not my place to socialise at events such as those. Have a pleasant stay."

Glimmer expects fireworks, but the negotiations come and go with little fanfare. Alei comes to collect her from her room a few hours after arrival, blushing profusely and fighting the urge to run away when she nearly walks in on Glimmer while she changes. Glimmer diffuses the situation with a smile and lets Alei walk her to the

town hall, an austere wooden building lined with ornate windows. Taking a seat, Glimmer finds a rudimentary star map already set up and covered in user-generated border lines and notes. The dreary timelessness of the town hall stands in stark contrast to what is being projected into the central space above, an iridescent array of light and colour.

As the hours pass, Glimmer finds herself more enthralled with this simple projection than Meora's bureaucratic drawl. The Felin Empire wants unfettered expansion, Glimmer wants to look at the stars. All this space, all this life. Who would want to subjugate that? The horror of looking at these little dots as some way of determining who owns what dawns on her without warning. It's another weight, but it gives her no comfort.

Though it seemed to have begun not long ago, the conference is over. Meora is gathering her few things, Alei struggling alone with reams of notes and diagrams. Glimmer stands, picks up the empty notepad and pen given to her as she walked in. She has no idea what was just agreed, and yet she has never been more sure of her next move in her life. Time to lift the weight.

She pushes the mighty horror of owning space to the back of her mind, for the purposes of the upcoming dance. A formal ball is not the place for zoning out, no matter how cold her hosts. Expecting to walk herself to the town hall this time, alone in the freezing evening, Glimmer opens the door to see the nervous face of Alei.

"I thought about what you said. No one has ever called me nice before. I would like to talk with you more, Queen Glimmer."

"That's great! Two unlikely friends at a dance together, having fun, talking about whatever. Just one thing; please don't call me Queen Glimmer. I'm just Glimmer, okay?"

"Sure, 'just Glimmer'."

"Was that a… oh, you cheeky girl!" Alei looks like she wants the world to swallow her until she catches sight of Glimmer's smirk.

“Come on, there will be plenty of time for jokes at the dance!” Glimmer slips her arm inside Alei’s, knowing the other girl is blushing profusely. They walk quietly, arm in shaking arm, towards the hall, feet crunching in sync on the gravel.

“Have you ever thought about leaving home, Alei?”

“N- no, of course not. The Empire treats me well, so what reason would I have to leave?”

“But there are so many stars out there. So much life. I can leave whenever I want, but being Queen binds me to Brightmoon. I could never make a new home for myself. You could.”

“Being assistant binds me to the Empire, to- to Meora.”

“I can tell you like her, you know. Like, *like* her. But if you’ve never been called nice before, never thought about leaving home… there's no freedom here, is there, Alei?”

“Freedom is- freedom is not something we are supposed to value.”

“But freedom is a part of life! Every person deserves free will and the chance to act on it!”

“Hush!” Alei has never spoken that loudly to Glimmer before, not even to Meora. “That is revolutionary thinking. If Meora heard that she would have me reprimanded.”

“You? But you said nothing.”

“You are a foreign Queen with status. Etheria would destroy the Felin Empire if anything happened to you. But I am just an assistant. They can do what they like to me.”

“That’s awful!” Glimmer tries to be quieter in her indignation, realising too late that they have reached the door to the hall. Alei swallows nervously and the pair enter.

The dance hall is beautiful, if only in the cold, stark style that seems to permeate the town. It almost reminds Glimmer of the Princess Prom, of Frosta's castle and its icy chandeliers, the sun taking a detour off towering pillars of ice. But it is dark on Ariabos, and the hall is not so tall, just full of dark crevices.

Time passes, as it has to do, and Glimmer meanders around the dancefloor and surrounding areas, as sure of her future duty as she is unsure of anyone's damn *name* . After making several circuits of the hall in the name of etiquette, she returns to the buffet table where she left Alei to find her frozen in place, head burrowed almost into her chest.

"Hey, Alei. You gonna stay there all night?"

"I- I've never been to an event like this before, not as a guest. Meora would kill me if she-"

"Who cares about what Meora thinks? Come on, let's have a dance!" Alei tries to murmur that she does, in fact, care what Meora thinks but her mumbles fall on deaf ears as Glimmer spins her around the dancefloor. Alei is surprised at how agile the Queen is, how she can move so freely when in the presence of so many others. Alei tries to find a pocket in the gentle rhythm of the music, tries to maintain pace with her partner, but is breathless by the time the beat switches and she is thrust into the arms of someone tall and familiar.

"You shouldn't be here."

"I'm sorry, M-"

"Hush. Because you are with the Queen, I will allow this, and maintain dance etiquette. But you must follow my movement until the music changes." Alei gulps down the worst of her nerves and lets her body become fluid in Meora's hold, their bodies slowly sliding in sync, the shifting drum patterns and her partner's guiding hands molding her like clay. It's almost fun, an unfamiliar sensation that nearly throws Alei off course, only to be caught in a

gentle dip by Meora's outstretched arm. Their faces are close, the hold tender. Alei is overcome with warmth, purring audibly, until she sees a bizarre expression on her partner's face. Shock. And the beginnings of blushing. They are saved from this frozen dip by another shift in music, and immediately Alei misses the sensation of Meora's hands on her body. She dances the rest of the night away in a restrained fashion, hunting out Meora with those heavy thoughts playing in her head.

Across the dancefloor, Glimmer has found herself a rather clingy partner. A short, stocky boy with a furrowed brow and oddly rough clothing has made his way through the dancers to Glimmer multiple times now, under what pretense she is unsure.

On their fourth meeting, Glimmer decides to breach the silence. "I'm not all too clear on your planet's etiquette, but generally dancers are meant to find a new partner with each change of music."

"I needed to talk to you, Queen Glimmer."

"You could have just done it the first time."

"It would have been unsafe if you weren't isolated."

"Now that's creepy. And will people stop calling me Queen Glimmer? It's not like I have any power here."

"But you do. I'm with the revolution, and I need to talk with you at length. Come with me." The boy grabs Glimmer's hand and drags her through a side door and out into the bracing cold. Meora might have noticed the Queen slip away, was she not searching for a different girl in the half-light.

"Ok, I'm fine with talking to whoever is your leader, but you could have at least warned me before dragging me out here! It's freezing."

"Noted. And, please keep your voice down."

“Geez, ok, why is everyone here so closed off?” Glimmer mutters under her breath.

“Because,” comes a booming voice in the shadows, “we have been oppressed for countless years. Follow me.”

“Voices in the shadows, weird revolutionary people dragging me out of dance halls, and far too many vague and very ominous responses. Will someone please tell me what is going on here?”

“I said, follow me.” Glimmer huffs, but obliges. These people are unarmed, and besides, she has Bow’s blaster, a parting gift from her boyfriend. Well, a gift as in ‘stolen from his bedside drawer late at night’. Ah, the things people will let slide for love. Hopefully.

Glimmer finds herself entering a snow covered tunnel way up the hill that separates two main sections of the town. The depths of the tunnel are pitch black and Glimmer wishes she had a connection to the runestone this far out. Luckily, her still-serious companion pulls out an unlit torch and matches, and the two are able to find their footing, as well as catch a glimpse of the owner of that booming voice. They are tall, muscular and scarred, a furred likeness of Huntara or for that matter anyone in the Crimson Waste. Glimmer never did like those types.

“Hey,” whispers Glimmer to her torch-bearing guide, “what’s their deal?”

“Their… deal? That is the legendary Kassi Kangelane, leader of the revolution against the tyrannical Felim Empire and hero of the people.”

“You know I can hear you both. And Gaman, you don’t have to pretend to be serious anymore.”

“Oh, I don’t? Thank god, that was killing me! Hi, I’m Gaman, or- well, you just heard Kassi say that so I guess hi again?”

“Hi, Gaman.” In an instant the gruff looking boy across from Glimmer had transformed into 5 feet of nervous energy, and it was throwing Glimmer off as she tried to formulate useful questions.

“So, Kassi, you’ve been leading a revolution against the Felin Empire for how long?”

“At least 10 years. Mostly by myself, but more recently I’ve had some help,” they gesture to Gaman, still bouncing around the tunnel.

“10 years- that’s forever! Why haven’t you made any moves against the Empire?”

“We did, a long time ago. Mostly the revolution is just a safe place for those who have been hunted down for their anti-government sentiments; we aren’t all built for fighting.” The tunnel opens out into a well lit cavern. Glimmer finds herself feeling warm again after nearly an hour’s worth of shivering, almost failing to notice in her comfort the countless civilians scattered around the cave. Some are ill, far more look badly injured.

“This cavern is a good hiding spot. At any sign of Empire agents, the tunnel entrance is rigged to close. These people need safety.”

“What- who did this to so many people?”

“I told you we were oppressed. Anti-government sentiments get you more than a stern warning on Ariabos.”

“This is why we need your help, Glimmer!” Gaman chimes in out of nowhere, his endless energy still a marvel. “These people have been hurt bad by the Felin Empire, but you can help us turn the tide!”

“I can try but… Etheria has been through a lot, ever since the Empire was just a rebellion fighting against the Horde. I’m pretty sure we shouldn’t even be an Empire! Especially after everything I’ve seen here, everything that the Felin Empire has done. Etheria

may have good intentions but it isn't our duty to rule, just to help."

"So why can't you help us?"

"Well, it's far more complicated than that- look, the Etherian Empire is for now a major galactic player, and any act of aggression against the Felin Empire would result in- in an all-out war. It's a tenuous relationship as it is with all of their demands for land and power. We can help you, but it will have to be a stealth mission. Prove that the Felin Empress has been abusing her people and silencing dissent, then take her from the throne and use the revolution as inspiration for the common populace to rise up. It'll be difficult, but I believe in you, in you all."

"The Empress is a threat of her own accord. She didn't inherit that power, she took it. The army disposed of Felin royalty a long time ago and it's been a power grab ever since." Kassi sounds hurt as they speak, and Gaman moves over to comfort them. "My family had a claim to the throne. She killed them all. I was the only one who got out."

"Kassi, I'm so sorry…" Glimmer trails off. Gaman seems to know them well enough to grant silent comfort, an arm reaching over broad shoulders.

"It's the past. I fight for the future, for the lives that these people deserve to live."

"You know, you remind me of my friend, Adora. She's brave and selfless and a brilliant leader, but I can't help but feel that the world beats her down for it too often. She beats herself up for it too. Sometimes I want the universe to scream at her that she deserves love too. Don't give up, Kassi. Not on these people, and not on yourself."

Glimmer makes note of the location of the tunnel and leaves with Gaman as her guide, promising a swift return with help in tow. No one questions why she left the dance early. Alei remains for most

of the night, clearing up after everyone in the small hours of the morning, and covering for Glimmer. She tells more lies in one night than she has ever done before, keeping nosy party guests at bay until she spots a face in the crowd that makes her weak again.

“You are a better liar than I thought, Alei.”

“How- how can you tell?” She knows better than to lie to her superior, forgetting that everyone else she had told about Glimmer’s fake illness had the status to get her exiled.

“Your eyes dilate rapidly when you lie. I’ve never seen anyone else do that. Are you going to tell me what happened to Glimmer?”

“I don’t know.” Her pupils remain in place.

“It doesn’t matter. The Empire got what it wants today.”

“Did you?” Meora swivels, Alei noticing that shocked expression again.

“Excuse me?”

“Did you get what you want?”

“I- you heard what I said. The Empire got what it wants. That is enough.” The pair go silent but rather than turning to leave, as Alei expects, Meora stays and starts cleaning.

“That isn’t work befitting an agent of Felin. You should-”

“I want to help.” They work quietly for two hours before heading home, and Alei almost offers to walk Meora to her door. Instead, they part in the cold morning air, faces bright red.

Glimmer knows it makes no sense that she is able to leave without protest. Meora should be coldly demanding answers to her unexpected absence from the party right now, but she is nowhere to be found. Neither is Alei. The mid-morning frost has

settled in, and Glimmer decides she has had enough of ice and cold air. Time to go home and fix everything. Or at least try.

Finding Control

Chapter Summary

> Catra tries to shrug off a stalker. Bow feels the pressure of day to day kingdom management.

Chapter Notes

> apologies that i suck at writing light and funny stuff so this chapter has plenty of angst to go along with the silly plot. 6 and 7 are going to go absolutely crazy i promise

Being in charge of a kingdom is, unsurprisingly, a tall order. With Micah in Mysticor and Glimmer away on Ariabos, Bow has to manage seven restless princesses, a talking horse, and one very depressed Adora. Where before Bow had managed to comfort his friend with a strong shoulder and kind words, Adora had locked her door directly after speaking to Glimmer and remained in her room even as Bow knocked gently, pleading for her to at least leave her room and get some air. Adora stayed silent.

"Is Adora dead of exhaustion again?" Frosta appears in Bow's field of vision, one day after Glimmer's departure.

"No, she's- she's working through some stuff right now. Just give her space."

"Oh, like the stuff with Catra? They were friends and then Catra left her and now she's all mopey-"

"Hey! Keep it down. But yea, Adora and Catra were… uh… good friends, for a while."

"They even slept in the same bed! I wish I had a friend who would sleep with me."

"Frosta, could you help me and Perfuma with some chores, please? Bow is a very busy man and you shouldn't just jump up

on him like that."

"No, it's- it's fine. But you should go help Scorpia, Frosta."

"Jeez, I have to do chores?! I thought Brightmoon was some sort of fucking paradise!"

"Did you just…" Bow is stunned into losing coherent sentences, while Scorpia just looks disappointed.

"Swear? Well, you guys do it all the time. Besides, I'm 14, Bow, relax."

"Well, I don't want to hear that foul language, Princess. And as punishment, I decree that you, by the power invested in me by Glimmer for like a week or two, have to go help Scorpia with all of her chores for today."

"Ugggghhhh, you are so uptight."

"Hey, I'm not-"

****

The desert beckons. Catra has fought through the Etherian coastline with few close calls and as a gloriously empty prize, can look into the vast expanse of the Crimson Waste. This is where she had nearly found a life, a home that cared so little it made her feel free. Absent-mindedly, she moves a stray hair out of her eyes, only just realising her hair is now long enough to do that. Hopefully the Waste has hairdressers, or the mane will be making it's reappearance, she thinks. Adora would never have let it get this long. Good. That was a sign she cared. Catra didn't. They were always different like that.

Finding her way to the Valley of Lost Souls with practised ease, Catra begins to make herself at home. The shacks and hovels have been replaced since her last visit, and Horde symbols no longer adorn banners or front doors. In fact, it is absent of most anything or anyone. Huntara must have rounded up the Horde

sympathisers during the war, having sent messages frequently to the Rebellion of her ongoing success at pacifying the region. But Catra knows better. The Crimson Waste will forever be a lawless land, and it will forever be her ideal home. It has to be.

As she scours the town for a suitable hovel to break into, Catra begins to hear footsteps mirroring hers. She has been lost in thought for long enough to let her guard down, and makes a mental reminder to keep away from the deeper parts of her mind. As she stops, the gentle pacing on sand that is starting to ring in her ears goes silent. Catra spins and starts pacing down every alley with menace. After stalking empty shadows for too long, she starts to suspect she has been hearing things, until the sound of wood creaking from a shack to her left pricks her ears up. Storming through the doorway, Catra finds herself staring down at He-Man. Again.

"H-hey Catra. I wasn't following you or anything. Just- doing my thing in the very cool and pleasant Crimson Waste."

"You creepy fuck!" Catra jumps at the cowering boy, catching the side of his face with her claws. She leaps and twists back, expecting an easy fight. But He-Man just curls up and starts sobbing.

"Gah! Don't try guilt-trip me. You can cry all you want, but you have been stalking me for too long. I am well within my rights to-"

"I know! I was trying to be a hero. But this place is so horrible! I was honestly going to leave you alone, because as much as I think you wronged all those villages and I want to stop you, I just can't. How can you want to live here?"

"Because no-one here cares. You must get that, right? I mean, if you have the opportunity to track some lowlife thief across half the planet, there can't be too many people looking out for you at home." Catra hates with all her heart that she feels bad for He-Man, she hates that this empathy and calmness is a product of

her time in Brightmoon, hates how she wants to comfort this weird little kid.

"Well, no, I don't. Not exactly. My family are lovely and- and they want the best for me, but since Mum died I've- why am I telling this to you? You are my enemy."

"We aren't exactly enemies, kid. I've had plenty of those, but being stalked and getting in a total of two very lacklustre fights isn't what I'd call lifelong rival material. And I'm- I am sorry to hear about your mum. Really. I may not be a great person but I know how it feels to lose someone you know so well."

"Well, thank you, Horde scum. I don't think you are such a bad person, after all. You know, I know that you saved the world, really."

"You do? But you said to me-"

"I wanted to play the hero. Every hero needs a villain, and there you were. The bad guy from all my stories. I even spoke to *her* once, after she saved my town from the army that- that was destroying so much. I asked her what it was like to be a hero, and to fight Catra and the rest of the evil Horde. When I said your name, she looked so- I can't describe it. It was what my dad looked like earlier that day. Before she had come. I thought you two hated each other, but she just looked so sad."

"Adora was probably just sad about all the people that had been killed. She always cared about them more than me."

"When I told her what had happened to my family, she didn't look like that. You hadn't even died, and she looked like that. I thought she was being selfish, but when I learned what happened with you guys and Horde Prime, I- I knew she loved you. It just made sense."

"How would you know anything about me?" Catra is screaming again, claws bared. He-Man looks so shocked, so rapt with terror, but Catra has forgotten how to care. "Get out of this shack, get

out of the Waste, and never speak to me again. You are just another part of her perfect little cult. It always has to be about love, doesn't it! Love has never mattered to me, so go!" The lie stings as it leaves, and He-Man knows it is a lie, but he goes anyway.

She blew up again, over something so small. It's not the fact it was at a kid, just that she became so weak in that moment. Adora still controls parts of her. That is the only explanation. Those parts have to go. Just to regain some control.

****

"How does Glimmer make this look so easy?"

Brightmoon is chaos. Frosta has taken out her anger at Bow by filling the castle with ice, including the ventilation system, the kitchen and everywhere else that she and Scorpia had been assigned to clean. The absence of cleaners in Brightmoon was a problem, one on a very long list that Bow found tucked away in Glimmer's bedside drawers. The list also included: finding a muting device for Swiftwind, stopping Seahawk from gaining access to matches, confiscating Mermista's Mermystery books for the sake of the guards who kept getting plots spoiled, and getting Casta to research antidepressants for Adora. Bow set the list on fire in a moment of panic, before returning to the crucible of fire outside his room with no idea what to do.

"Scorpia, you have to help with the castle. Frosta brought the whole thing to a complete halt; Entrapta is complaining she doesn't have any tiny food, and Adora just left her room for the first time in like, a day to say that she is freezing to death because of all the ice, and Mermista has disappeared to stop Seahawk from teaching her entire palace a sea shanty, and-"

"Ok, Bow, it is going to be ok, you just need to breathe for a second." Perfuma appears from behind Scorpia's back and sits down by his side, ready to meditate.

“I don’t need to meditate, I need to fix the castle! Glimmer is going to be so upset when she gets back, oh god, and then she won’t be my friend and Adora is- well she is not in a good place right now, and I don’t know how I can fix that if she won’t talk to me and oh!” Bow spots Frosta in the midst of his breakdown making a run for her room. “Hey, Frosta, come back here!” His cries fall on deaf ears. “Scorpia, can you help restrain her?”

“I can try, but she is a *mean* little kid when she wants to be so don’t blame me if we both get hurt.” With Scorpia’s help, Bow breaks through Frosta’s locked door to find her crying quietly on her bed, so small and alone.

“Hey, uh-”

“Get out! Unless you can get Glimmer here, I don’t want to talk to either of you.”

“Glimmer’s away on her mission, Frosta. I don’t see why you can’t talk to me and Scorpia.”

“I know she is, dummy. But you won’t listen to me. Not like she does. And even Micah’s not here.”

“Hey, don’t dismiss Bow like that. He’s a wonderful listener, and a wonderful friend. You wouldn’t be here right now if he hadn’t kept Adora, Glimmer and the rest of the Alliance functioning.”

“Look, I don’t want to intrude on your personal life, just, why did you do all of that to the castle?”

“I- Glimmer never told me to do anything. She would always make it fun, and so I never really thought of work as chores. She was the one around here who actually cared about me, and then Micah started to really care too, but I feel like no-one takes me seriously.”

“So you ruined the castle to make people take you seriously?”

“I thought you would all think I was so powerful. But I ruined it for everyone!”

“We do think you are powerful! You’re such a talented fighter and everyone knows it. There haven't exactly been a whole lot of battles lately, but that doesn’t mean you’ve lost our respect. You’re our friend Frosta, even if we aren’t always great at showing it.”

“T-thank you Bow.”

“Now come on, let’s get this castle cleaned up. And no, you don’t have to do any chores after that, at least for today. When Glimmer gets back you can talk to her about it.”

The three proved to be remarkably efficient at de-icing the palace. With Scorpia hoisting Frosta into vents and Bow making note of all the affected rooms, Frosta was able to force out the excess ice through the waste pipes with minimal damage, and Mermista even made it back early from her emergency excursion to aid the process. The Alliance was working together again, if only to solve a domestic issue, and the Princesses even felt the tingling of their old magic as the last of the ice left the castle. Maybe, thought Bow, he wasn’t such a bad leader after all.

“Adora, hi, so we fixed the ice problem. Your room should be warmer now.” Silence. “You know, you could at least talk to me about something. I know Glimmer and I upset you, but if you really let one disagreement get in the way of a friendship, then-”

“Then what, Bow?”

“Just, think about talking to me, or at least saying hi. We all miss seeing you around.”

Inside the foul smelling, horribly messy bedroom Adora has been using as a temporary base of operations, she is starting to gather a plan together. She is going to run away. She is going to find Catra. She is going to tell her how she feels. She is going to give her that reason. All she needs is to work out what the reason is.

The Moon

Chapter Summary

Catra finds a familiar face in the Crimson Waste.

Chapter Notes

catgirl goes to therapy
parts of this were heavily inspired by the microphones song 'the moon'
chapter 7 is even sadder than this im so sorry

“That was a mighty fine performance, kitten.”

Catra has stayed inside for what feels like hours, her mind racing with thoughts of everything and nothing in the aftermath of He-Man’s hasty departure. And now, to top off another horrific day, that familiar nickname and infinitely annoying sense of dramatic timing.

“I mean, you really had me going, all that sappy backstory stuff. The drama! The closed off villain showing a brief sign of empathy! And then, the wonderful twist! So much pain, all these feelings and all that riveting anger. Bravo, darling. I could only hope to elucidate such emotion in my own performances.”

“Why do you always show up? What is it about you that thrives off of other people’s… situations?”

“There is theatre everywhere, kitten. When you live for long enough, you get rather good at spotting it, even predicting it.”

“Predicting it? You mean you can-”

“I don’t have farsight, if that’s what you’re asking. But, every story has a pattern, and every character has their arc. Basically, people are predictable, from their actions to their expressions. I got so

good at reading them, that acting became my natural calling, a profession where I can inhabit the very minds of-”

“Yeah, whatever. So- so can you predict what is going to happen… with me?”

“Well, not if you ask me for it. See, if I tell you, then all the fun is spoiled.” Double Trouble wanders into the evening halflight, their tail snaking around Catra’s small, shaking form. “If you know the most logical progression, your actions will be irreparably affected by that knowledge. Either you will knowingly follow that story, and all the wonderful drama will be sucked away, or you will purposefully act against the flow of things, and that-” They pause and place a rough hand under Catra’s downturned jaw, “-just doesn’t make for a good story.”

“So you’re here just to torment me?”

“Oh, of course not kitten! You take me for some sort of villain. Sure, my morals are not exactly-” They grasp the opportunity for irony and shift forms, adopting the muscular body and horribly familiar face of Adora, “-upstanding. I’m no great and powerful hero, of course.”

Catra shrieks and dashes into the darkness, Adora’s presence blocking that prized escape route.

“Whoops! Forgot you guys weren’t on, how should I put it, speaking terms.”

“Forgot? You know about…”

“Oh, everyone does! It’s the talk of the town. And in fact, this little tangent that seems to cause you so much pain can help answer your earlier question.”

“I won’t talk to you. Not about *her* .”

“You will have to. At some point.”

“No I won’t. I’ll stay here, make the life that I was always going to resort to. The Crimson Waste is a lawless land, it’s devoid of emotion, it’s perfect.”

“Huntara has softened this place up plenty, and from the looks of it, so have you. Scared, defenseless, alone. You didn’t even notice me waiting for the whole of your little spat earlier. Besides, anything that goes wrong gets reported to Brightmoon. It’s mighty difficult to be lawless on Etheria now.”

“What do you want from me? Did Adora pay you to get some surrogate apology out of me?”

“My manipulative mercenary days are long over, kitten. Those twists get mighty boring after the second time, so now I act on my own agency. Literally.”

“So, what? You’re just giving me advice?”

“Think of it as an emergency intervention. Now, let’s get started. No time to waste, Adora will be trying to find you pretty soon, and you have to be prepared.”

“Adora is- how do you know what she’s planning?”

“Again, we aren’t in kahoots. That would be horrifically boring, and anyway, I’ve only ever spoken to her in that awful Flutterina role. She’s just incredibly predictable, and incredibly in love with you.”

“She isn’t! She had no reason to love me. As I predicted.” Catra lets the word drawl out of her mouth. She is utterly hopeless on this shack floor, so why not open up to that one bastard lizard who always catches her in these situations.

“Oh kitten, have you ever considered that the reason might be you?”

“M-me?” Catra is stunned out of her rage for a blinding moment.

“Well, of course I never quite saw what she saw in you. I’m more into the big, dumb, loveable type, you know, everything you aren’t, but somehow she found a way to love you to the end of Etheria and beyond. Again, literally.”

“No, that makes no sense. She has to have some reason, or it’s- or it’s for nothing.”

“It doesn’t make sense to people like us. But for her-”

“Like us? I’m nothing like you!”

“Logical people. People who rationalise emotions, and when those emotions cannot be rationalised they break. You think this facade goes all the way? I have my moments, kitten, not quite like you do, but that whole meta theatre nerd thing gets awfully tiring after a while.”

“Adora is logical. She’s a leader, and brave, and she will never be selfish in her life ever and will you stop making me talk about her?” Catra is crying now, memories of every broken moment clouding her vision, each tear drop a resonance unlocking windows into the darkest corners of a murky psyche.

“By your own admission, Adora is an idiot. An idiot who saved your life after years of fighting, after you nearly ended the universe because you were repressed. If you can’t see how much she cares, maybe you’re the bigger idiot after all. Ooh, what a fun twist!” Double Trouble has taken on that haunting form again, and not even for some sick joke. The hair poof is normal sized, at least.

“You don’t know us. You don’t know me!”

“We’ve been over this, kitten. I’m awfully good at reading people, but the only words I can make out on you are scrawled on scraps of paper that say, ‘I hurt people’. It’s not a good look.”

“I tried to be a good person. For them all. Like Entrapta said. But there was no reason for them to accept that. I was always going

to hurt them."

"And then you did! God, if you weren't so bad at reading your own emotions this would have been no fun. Seriously, you drove people away because you were worried about driving people away? Anyone with half a brain would have seen the stupidity of that, but not you. It feels like even I'm missing something."

"I get it, I'm terrible. Just- please change… *character* to something- different."

"That's the worst thing. You think you are the most terrible person in the world. It would be wonderfully dramatic if it wasn't so wrong." Double Trouble pulls the tender face caress trick again, only this time it feels so genuine.

"You're just telling me what Adora wants me to think."

"Well of course, darling. She wants you to be happy, and so do I. Well, I do because it's been years of constant pain for you and the story is really starting to suffer from all those emotional beats getting hit over and over again, but it's broadly the same thing."

"Leave me alone, please. I don't want to hear any more of your manipulation."

"Oh, but you need to hear it. For once in your life, you need something. And for someone who I can only assume has been on both the receiving end and giving end of plenty of manipulation, you really don't know the definition of that word. It's important for actors to understand their script, don't you know?" Their form shifts as the final nail is extracted from Catra's coffin. "Well, I must be going now. Ta ta, kitten."

Catra stays in that stinking wreck of a building for hours. She does not sleep, not even after such a long day. Eventually, some wretched looking creature comes home and, irked but not shocked at their new and rather pitiful home invader, kicks the cat out. The kick and the landing are rough against Catra's battle worn body, but she doesn't have the strength to care. Dusting her

body off, wiping away the remains of tear streams, she stands up with shaking legs, the night breeze moving ragged tufts of hair around. The valley walls are all she can see from down in its depths, but the moon is awfully bright. Catra turns her sensitive eyes away at first, but finding no comfort in the dirt, returns to stare the sky down. She goes back to the alleyways to forget, to feel alone. There is nothing left for her. All she can see, through the beginnings of more tears, are crooked rooftops and the blue light of the moon. It is almost comforting.

Stay

Chapter Summary

> Adora has a second vision, the night before leaving Bright Moon. Glimmer returns to her beloved Bow and a far-too knowledgeable guest.

Chapter Notes

> ok fuuuuuuuuuuuck this chapter is soso sad. its also very plot heavy in the second half and my favourite minor character in the entire world is back already because i just love writing them so much. please keep leaving kudos it means a lot to me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora has been confined for so long, the sky is starting to look like a bedroom. She feels the flow of night air on her skin and loose nightgown, the spaces devoid of presence in her room so much greater than the unconfined vastness beyond her balcony. One more tortured night until she runs away. Bow said something that made her laugh earlier in the evening, his taking to Adora's bedroom door when the castle is starting to slumber a new but welcome occurrence. He tells Adora stories and imitates Seahawk's endless balladry. Adora's silence was meant to be intimidating, but it welcomes Bow's rambling. A familiar narrative.

He left after hours of talking, reassured by the warm tone of his friend's laughter echoing into the depths of the night. That's when Adora began to notice all those spaces, and sought comfort in the night sky. Not very comforting, not with the weight of her decisions surrounding her, a murky half imagined blackness seeping into bedroom crevices guarded for so long by the life cycle of a day's sun.

Adora's head hits her bed, unsure how she made it away from the balcony. Then it is utterly dark and a room that is so undefined

that it cannot be familiar sparks traveled pathways in her brain. Three succinct flashes. The darkness retreats and Adora is in Brightmoon again, instead all she can make out is the wall of the infirmary and she knows this is painfully unreal, something in the unrendered murkiness of the scene lets the illusion slip, but that mass of beds and ornate paintings across the room is striking nonetheless. Adora wills her perspective to change and notices she is old, her frail hands sprawled on the bright white bedsheets. Her eyes have no corner here; what is real is simply in front of her, and yet a familiar form sneaks into the fuzz at her perspective's edge. Catra. She is sitting in a lone chair. Suddenly Adora is filled with the knowledge that she has already seen all of her friends stand around her in this same bed, just hours earlier. That she never expected to see ears and a tail in the crowd. That she hoped to see them anyway. Catra is alone now; she looks so small, bathing in the reflected light from endless frescos.

"Hey, Adora." She sees that familiar face speak those familiar words as if they were pressed together, as if Adora's eyesight hadn't begun to fail so long ago.

"You came back." Adora doesn't really speak those words; she's not sure that she can. But Catra hears.

"I always was better than you."

The silence hangs for so long, being as it is so practiced by exploring the miles separating decades of conversation.

"Why are you here now? What have I done to you this time?"

"Nothing. And some part of me wishes you had."

"I did so much."

Catra scoffs and stands up slowly.

"Don't worry, I know you were a great hero or whatever. This is a hero's death, isn't it?"

“I never wanted to be one, really.”

“You look so miserable. Couldn’t you at least die with a smile on your face? I mean, I came back for you. After so many years.”

“How many-”

“Long enough for you to forget.”

“You never make anything clear with me, do you? At least, you never try to.”

“A very long time ago, you promised me something. I came here, to watch you die, so that I could tell you how broken that promise is. I’m dying too, Adora.”

“So this is all for spite? To punish me?”

“I’m too old for that, too broken, too hurt. No, I came back for another promise because, secretly, I’m an idiot too.” They almost laugh in unison. Even the thought of it hurts.

“I can’t promise you anything more, Catra.”

“Yes, you can.” Catra leans into the stark white bed, her face filling the image Adora had been holding in her mind this whole time. “Please don’t die, Adora. I’m so scared. Promise me you won’t give up on this stupid life. I can’t go without seeing your face at the end.”

Adora barely registers twin pools collecting on her gown, how Catra’s fresh tears are starting to flow into hers.

“We never got another dance, Adora.”

“That first one was the best, anyway. I always liked you in a suit.”

“Don’t make me blush while you die, you idiot.”

“Did you hate me, until now? Do you hate me?” Catra goes silent again.

“If I ever truly did, I would have been so sorry for it.”

They let a slow stillness fill the hospital room. Adora starts to feel the ground pulling her back down, and Catra can feel the light fading as she reaches around to grab Adora’s limp body. It’s so heavy for something so frail.

“Stay, Adora. Stay. Why didn’t you ever fucking stay, Adora? Why didn’t you ever fucking stay? You promised! You promise-” The last scream is cut away by three quick flashes.

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Adora is sitting on the edge of her bed, getting dressed in a warm, sunlit room for the last time in what may end up being far too long. The sky, being a bedroom, holds aloft the same auburn tones as Adora’s surroundings.

There has always been a rhythm to her morning routine. Everything has to be regular, consistent. It’s a shadow from the past, but Adora was never able to shake it in all her years with the Rebellion. Adora’s rhythm is broken now, her socks and shoes thrown on without care, her jacket left in the corner. Emptiness takes full hold of her room as she begins her descent into the Whispering Woods.

****

Glimmer is nervous as her ship touches down. It’s a weird feeling, to be apprehensive about coming home, but she knows the feeling is unfounded. She has been sure of her decision for a week of space travel, a week spent alone with her thoughts, something that not long ago frightened her into talking to her worst enemy. Some part of Glimmer hopes that *she* will have come back, that Adora will have a smile on her face thanks to Bow’s relentless friendship and the presence of the one person Adora is, or was, so deeply in love with, and the best friend squad can live in peace forever.

Glimmer remembers what her father said to her on one stressful day after the war: “Peace is not equilibrium. At all stages of life unrest and struggle will be present. Your job as queen is to give others as much peace as possible. Your job as a person is to enjoy that peace, even if it is fleeting.” Glimmer didn’t understand at the time. She just nodded, in that way most people do when they mishear something for a third time and give up on their ears. All this angst was proving to be a pretty good teacher, after all.

The ship door opens, Glimmer bids a fond farewell to Darla, and runs straight into Bow’s open arms. They hug for a pleasant eternity, but as soon as Glimmer flashes them both away into the throne room and their arms release Bow’s face becomes downcast.

“She’s gone, Glimmer.”

“Who- oh. Oh! Bow, how could- did you *try* and talk to her?”

“Yes! Of course I did, Glimmer! She wouldn’t even let me in her room. I would just sit outside the door for hours and try and get through to her but all she ever did was sulk. I think I got one laugh out of her.”

“Oh. I’m- oh god, I’m so sorry Bow, the first thing I do when I get back is blow up at you because you couldn’t get through to our incredibly stubborn and *incredibly* depressed friend, which definitely isn’t something you should have to do, but you did it anyway, and I do *not* deserve you at a-”

“Yes you do, dummy. It’s ok! It’s ok to be upset. I’m upset too, and I can’t say I’ve been the nicest to everyone around here. Let’s just be calm about this, maybe, and then work on a way to find her.”

“Thank you Bow. I really do love you so much, you know?”

“I know. I love you too, silly.”

“Hey! Don’t call me silly. I am your Queen!”

"Glimmer, you know your Queenly voice sucks so much, right? And you don't even like being called Queen!"

"I knowwww, I was playing along. Now, come on, we need to work out where in Etheria Adora has got to."

"I can help with that." Taking the wind out of Bow, and by extension Glimmer, who he clung to at the first sign of danger, Catra appears in the doorway.

"God, this trick really works on everyone, doesn't it? Seriously, it would be so much more *fun* if you weren't all so needlessly dramatic." Catra's face shifts into one less familiar and less welcome visage, slitted eyes blinking with a deliberate menace.

"Hello, Double Trouble. I haven't seen you since our last little trick went so well."

"It's been such a long time, hasn't it, Queen Sparkles? Well, I'm here now, because there is a magnificent story brewing around you two and your blonde friend, not to mention everyone's favourite kitten."

"Yes, we are having some… issues," interjects Bow, "but you don't get to mess with us this time."

"I should have expected this after my precious kitten was so horribly mean to me in the Crimson Waste, but I'm not here for nefarious reasons, darling."

"Catra is in the Crimson Waste?!" Glimmer and Bow nearly rush to Darla in that moment before remembering their guest.

"Shit! I was *not* meant to tell you that right away. God, of all times to go off script! The writer is really gonna have my neck for that one. Oh well, might as well keep pursuing this storyline then." Double Trouble keeps at their mumbling, leaving Glimmer and Bow stranded in the desire to act and the need to prevent DT from being a bastard lizard. "Yes, your precious Catra is in the

Wastes. And if my predictions are correct, and they always are, then Blondie is on her way to find her."

"Adora left to- to go find Catra?" Bow's voice is starting to crack again, a familiar sound from a darker time. Not much darker, really.

"Are you really so surprised? You must know how much she loves that grumpy kitten. And from what I can gather, she wasn't exactly on the best of terms with you two."

"Well, uh- yes. Um. How did you know that?"

"I observe, darling. It's part and parcel of being such a fabulous actor, who only ever went off script one time and it will *not* happen again."

"So Adora has gone to find Catra, who is in the Wastes, and Adora is definitely going to find her because she is so goddamn stubborn when she wants to be, and you know all of this because you spoke to Catra and have definitely been stalking us." Glimmer is pacing about her throne room, a bundle of nerves and too much information.

"Well, if you put it like that, it's no fun. But yes, that's the gist of it."

Glimmer begins to panic, before taking a look at the equally stressed Bow next to her, and that saying of her father's appears in her brain again. *Your job as queen is to give others as much peace as possible.* Three deep breaths and a warm hand on Bow's shaking shoulder, and Glimmer steadies herself to look Double Trouble directly in the eyes.

"Take us to Catra."

"No."

****

Adora has been running for hours. The morning sun that served as a crimson beacon has grown up, now searing her pale skin from high in the sky. Burning sensations on her barely protected arms and neck, or her hair waving in front of her eyes, have slowed her down, but something primal keeps her legs moving with arrhythmic determination. She doesn't know where Catra has gone, she has no map, and she is short on supplies. Anyone with the presence of mind would have turned back long ago, but Adora is set on living with her choices, except if those choices drag her apart from her only light in the dark.

She stumbles upon a quiet town in the late afternoon. The sun is old, nearing retirement, its rays angled across thatched roofs. Her hands are dirty but she needs to eat, having brought little food on her voyage. Entering the town, Adora sees no-one, but her eye catches on the ragged, decaying doll of She-Ra laying on the cobbled floor. She begins to cry, alone and lost, before someone emerges from the shadows. "Adora?"

"Who- who are you?" Adora shifts around at the mention of her own name to be greeted by a ragged looking child in a torn costume.

"I'm He-Man, and I'm so happy I found you."

****

"What do you mean, no?"

"Oh, darling, you are so naive! I can't interfere with the story, not like that at least."

"Will you stop being weird and murmuring about stories for two seconds so you can help us? That, or get out of my castle."

"You have to let Adora carry out her part of the-" Double Trouble notices Glimmer's glare and reconsiders their script, "-of her life. She didn't run away from you, she ran towards Catra. You can forgive her for being hurt and in love, right? God, if not I *really* misread how close you all were to each other…"

“They’re right Bow.”

“They’re- what?”

“We have to let Adora do this. I know we always say we’ll support her in what she does but this isn’t some big monster or evil space cult. It’s a girl that Adora still loves so much. Not our place. What we can do, is dismantle the empire, and make good on a promise of my own.”

Glimmer regaled her time on Ariabos to her boyfriend, and of course that bastard lizard, under the condition that they would remain guarded and watched for their whole time in Brightmoon. After Glimmer was finished, they slipped away anyway.

“So you really want to go back on all this progress?”

“I know, it’s hard. But it will only help the universe in the long run, and besides, we don’t have to start right away. The first order of business will be assembling a crack team to help the revolution on Ariabos and give them independence from an oppressive regime.”

“And what if that revolution wants an empire of its own?”

“Then we let them. The issue with the Felin Empire is not its intention but its methods, and besides, Kassi and the other revolutionaries have seen too much of what power can do to people. I think they will be happy with helping their own planet for a long time.”

“You do make a wise Queen, Glimmer.”

“Well, I learnt from the best, and my support along the way wasn’t half bad either.” Glimmer pulls a cheeky grin and earns a hug and profuse blushing from Bow in return. Their optimism is, like always, tainted with anxiety and stress, but they can’t help being happy in each other’s arms anyway.

****

“Who the fuck is He-Man? And- have you been stalking me?”

“Ok, well, He-Man isn’t really a thing, it’s just some legend I read about after history class, but he’s really cool and punches bad guys and stuff, and uh- I have not been stalking you, why does everyone assume that? Do I just look creepy or something? No, I’ve been staying in this town, collecting information on my nemesis.” During this squeaky-voiced monologue, Adora is baffled into silence. What did some kid and his obsession with mythology have to do with her?

“And who exactly is your nemesis?”

“Catra, the evil commander of the-”

“What?! You know- oh my god this is incredible! You’ve seen Catra, recently from the looks of you. Those claw marks are definitely going to scar, trust me, and you can- you must know roughly where she is! This is- well Perfuma always says to thank the universe which is dumb but I guess thank you?”

“Isn’t Catra your enemy, too?”

“She was, which I’m sure you know about, but we also saved the world together, and we *were* together, and it’s- hey, why are you crying?”

“I know all of that! Why do I do this! I make it into this good guys and bad guys thing! And it’s not that at all! God, I’m such an idiot.”

“Um. Well, uh, it’s ok. I’m not upset. I was. Actually, I still might be. Mind if I cry with you?”

Adora remembers her dream, He-Man remembers his conversation in the Wastes, and they cry together for a short few hours in the abandoned streets.

“Catra loves you. I think,” He-Man forces out through sobs.

“I hope so.”

Silence falls on the town again. Adora feels the weight of her emotions, and crawls into the bushes to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

ok will be taking a small break from this fic because i burnt myself out slightly
next chapter will be finished in a few weeks

Save The Cats

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer organises a strike team to save Ariabos from the Empress. Alei escapes the Empire but struggles to leave Meora behind.

Chapter Notes

> wooooo im back
> long and mostly action chapter but no catradora because 9+10 are all about them and Glimmer needed to do more good things
> also sorryyy about the title it was too good an opportunity

Letting Adora run away feels… *weird* . It is not in Bow's language of platonic love to allow his friend to leave in an unprepared hurry after a girl who spent a long, long time trying to kill her with claws and slightly less time preparing to kill her by running away. Bow has love for quite literally everyone, but Catra is difficult. Always has been, even as she gained a half comfort in her place as the fourth member of the Best Friend Squad. And now, with how broken Adora has been for so long, with all these memories piling up on him of Catra being an actual universe-ending dictator wannabe, he is struggling to extend love to Catra. A love that would, ideally, manifest itself in unwavering support for Adora. It is not doing that. What is most confusing, however, is Glimmer's lack of complaint, her prescience of mind to hear the sense in Double Trouble's nonsense, as if her distrust of Catra that lingered even as the two became close is suddenly not a factor. Watching his girlfriend organise the upcoming trip to Ariabos in an unfamiliar reverie, seeing her stumble upon reminders of their first time together in the ship, escaping Horde Prime, it dawns on Bow. Glimmer is letting Adora go on this mission because she knows that Adora had run after her in the same way, and she is letting her do it alone because frankly, no one else in Brightmoon understood Catra like Adora. Glimmer has made a split second

decision that considers her own complex feelings, the desire of her friend and what will allow her to help the most people in the best way. God, she has become so smart. Bow pulls himself out of his head and across the makeshift docking area to embrace Glimmer, a wonderfully familiar feeling.

"Heyy, darling. This is a- uh, nice surprise hug." Glimmer is caught off guard but her blush and return of the embrace belies any discomfort she might have wanted to show, being interrupted in her work.

"You are so special, and talented, and amazing, and I'm so proud of you." Glimmer says nothing in response but blushes harder and sinks into her boyfriend's arms. "Now, are we ready to leave?"

"We might have been if you were any help! Frosta and Scorpia have almost finished loading the necessary supplies, not that either of them stayed focused." Glimmer shoots a disapproving look at the two princesses turning their duties into a needlessly complex game. "And, uh- Bow, why are we bringing a literal *child* on what could be a *very* dangerous mission?"

"I was kinda… mean to her, while you were gone. I owe her. And besides, look how happy she is with Scorpia! Even Entrapta is being nice to her. " Indeed, it was a pleasant surprise to see the self professed 'child-phobe' tech princess taking a liking to Frosta. "It's good for her to have some actual parental figures."

"You were *mean* to her! You?! Well, that changes everything! She deserves a banquet of apology."

"I know you're only messing with me, but please don't bring up the 'Bow being mean' thing ever again. All that responsibility really did something to me. I don't know how you manage it." Glimmer cools her mockery and stares off into the distance, Bow's arm draped over her shoulder. It quickly dawns on her the reason for the impromptu interruption earlier. In the cool light of the docking bay, Glimmer smiles as hard as she ever has.

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Scorpia is bored. That is something she knows for sure, but the feeling is unfamiliar. Frosta is asleep, Perfuma is god knows how many miles away, and Glimmer and Bow are… in their room. Truth be told, Scorpia isn't exactly sure how all *that* works between a guy and girl, considering that she has only ever felt attraction to two people and both of them happen to align themselves with the feminine side of things (though at one point, Catra had confided in Scorpia about wanting to be referred to with 'he' pronouns and although this confused her no end, she obliged happily for a good month or two before Catra called the idea off). Of course, the fifth member of this little rescue party is sitting in front of her, babbling incessantly as she has done for so many years. Comfortable in her zoned out state, trusting that Entrapta won't pull her out of her reverie, Scorpia starts to wonder about how exactly she has maintained such a strong bond with a girl that, by all rights, she has nothing in common with. Back in the Horde, these little moments of zoned out Scorpia and info vomit Entrapta came as a result of shared anxieties, the expulsion of niggling doubts and fears. For Scorpia, that would all rotate around Catra, how she was feeling, how she was holding up, whether they would be able to meet for lunch next week. It was unlike Scorpia to be so thoughtful, and the quietness even shocked Entrapta out of her ranting the first few times it happened, but just talking to Catra never quite got all those swirling thoughts out. Mainly because she got shut down, always. But Catra is different now. Was different now? Scorpia had been so unsure of what to make of the whole Catra and Adora situation, but having seen Adora drag herself around in possibly the most depressed state Scorpia has ever seen a person function in, her gut reaction to stand up for Catra is starting to feel more and more stupid. Sure, Adora and her won't ever get along in the immutable, easy way that she bonds with Entrapta or Perfuma, but Scorpia owes her support and care. Well, she would have, had Adora not ran off before this whole mission. At least she's trying to fix things. That thought stirs a familiar feeling in her, because of course Scorpia had tried to do the same thing for god knows how long. Landing

comfortably on this thought, she becomes aware of just how much time has passed, and wills herself into the present. Time to do the same for a friend. "Hey, 'Trapta?"

"Oh! Hello, Scorpia. I hope I didn't ramble for too long this time." Entrapta decides to carry out the same pleasantries as always, for once dealing with a comforting subtext that the two girls both understand.

"It's fine, 'Trapta. In fact, I wanted to ask you a question."

"Is it about my theories on quantum entanglement?" Entrapta is unsurprised when Scorpia shakes her head gently. Though she would never normally be so covert about the meaning of a conversation, friendships have traditions. This is a crucial fact she learned a long time ago, and so far it has been unchallenged.

"What does friendship mean? I know you'll probably give me a very science-y answer, which is fine, I love that you do that, but I just wanted to know your perspective."

Entrapta pauses, and almost gives Scorpia what she doesn't want. Giving an opinionated answer here poses an interesting dichotomy, it is both scientifically invalid and the most scientifically interesting answer to say. Entrapta decides it doesn't matter and forms the words that will, according to her numbers, make her friend happiest. "I don't really know. For me at least. I think… I enjoy spending time with you, and all the other princesses, and Bow, and that feeling is returned as evidenced by their actions and body language. We all choose to spend time with each other, to make each other happy in some small way. I don't see why it would be anything other than that. At least, that is what the objective evidence suggests." Entrapta returns to tradition for the sake of comfort, almost breaking the illusion with a facial tick.

"I like that answer. It's definitely the logical, smart one, knowing you." It is very nice to be known, Entrapta decides. Facts about other people really are just as interesting as the world.

Bow breaks the smiling silence by bursting into the kitchen where Scorpia and Entrapta had taken up residence many hours ago, Frosta at his side. "We're closing in on Ariabos. Entrapta, are the bots ready? Oh, and Scorpia, get ready for some fighting."

"The bots have been ready for weeks, Bow! They are the most advanced scouting tools in the known universe! Complete with-" Scorpia interrupts her friend for the sake of everyone but her in the room.

"Entrapta will get them set up, yea. And don't worry about me. I'm used to being the muscle."

"Good to hear, everyone. I can always go over the exact plan, if anyone's unclear?" Shaking heads around the room, except for a meek nod from Frosta.

"Sorry, I fell asleep during the briefing." Bow begins a disapproving frown, remembers the past debacle, and adopts a strained smile instead.

"That's… fine! I'll just go over it again. Yea." Bow sighs and begins his pre rehearsed summary. "Entrapta will engage Darla's cloaking and send out the scouting bots to get a lay of the land, which will be transmitted back to a screen for us all to see. With Glimmer's guidance, one of the bots will find the revolution hideout and give them a message alerting them of our presence and plan. When we actually land, Entrapta will stay here under the protection of bots and cloaking while the rest of us find the revolutionaries. In fact, this reminds me," Bow breaks from his script to hand the squad their earpieces, Glimmer included after she had teleported into the kitchen, "we can communicate with these. Now, Glimmer will be in charge of co-ordinating the revolutionary effort alongside me and the leader of the resistance on Ariabos, Kassi Kangelane. Scorpia and Frosta, you are here for any fighting that may occur. According to Kassi, the revolution has been gaining momentum since Glimmer's visit, and many towns across the Empire, as well the few independent nations outside of it, have shown support for overthrowing the regime. Kassi is confident

that the revolution can make its move without our help, though correspondence has gone pretty dark in the past week or two. Either way, our job is to confront the government directly and ask them to step down under charges of abuse of power and violent acts of censorship."

"Wait, wait, wait! We are going in there, just four of us, to ask the Empress nicely if she will pretty please step down? Isn't she, like, a war criminal?" Frosta exclaims indignantly.

"Well, we can't just start with violence. The Etherian Empire is, uh, rebranding as a galactic peacekeeping force, not hired thugs. If the Empress shows resistance, then- well, that's what you and Scorpia are here for. She will have guards, but most of the fighting will happen across the planet. As long as you guys subdue any threats and arrest the Empress, it'll be fine. And that is only if she doesn't peacefully accept her crimes. No punching until we get punched, Frosta."

"It's a wonderful plan!" Entrapta reppears in the conversation, eager to ramble. "I have been doing plenty of calculations and, excluding the influence of extreme anomalies, this little operation has a remarkably high chance of succeeding! Of course, I can't say exactly what the probability is anymore, after finding out that very strange First One phenomenon known as 'resolution' and realising that all those exact percentages I'd given over the years were probably very, very off, which is-" Scorpia does the room a favour again and shouts even louder than mid-explanation Entrapta, an impressive feat.

"Yes, 'Trapta. You wouldn't stop talking about it for months after that one excavation. But I think the people here would rather prepare for the mission." Bow gives an encouraging nod. The impromptu meeting disperses and in separate rooms five of Etheria's finest don their battle gear and puff up their chests for the first mission in a long time packed with risk.

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“Alei, you can’t be here.” Meora is trying to stay composed in front of a shaken, familiar face, but even this interaction is doomed to collapse. “You know what will happen. The Empress knows you defected. I should be arresting you right now.”

“But you aren’t,” Alei murmurs, still clearly rattled by the horrors outside the castle walls.

“It’s the least I can do. One more thing for you.”

“You taught me what love is, Meora.” Both girls blush and a terse silence descends, the immediate danger and anxiety fading into the background. “You don’t have to do anything more for me. But you could come with me.”

“No. This is- I am loyal to the Empress.”

“Who cares about loyalty?” Alei’s rage is uncharacteristic and paints shock on Meora’s downturned face.

“Those revolutionaries really got to you. So quickly, as well. I would have hoped you cared about your home, about me, more.”

“I care more than I ever did, Meora. Why do you think I’m here now? I could have run. But I wanted to at least see you again.”

“I’m sorry, Alei. I really am.”

“Don’t be. Anything I feel is my own burden. That’s another thing you taught me.” Alei’s tone turns accusational, another new colour on her.

“I was- I wanted you to be stronger, bolder! To rise up the ranks like I did. We could have served… together.”

“That was never for me, Meora. If you really loved me, you would have seen that. See, you might have taught me what love is, but I had to learn its use myself. So I guess I will say goodbye, now.” Alei’s expression is cold again but her tears are searingly hot.

“Run, Alei. Forget this place. Run far away, and please never look back. That’s an order.” Alei completes her final task and, sobbing profusely, returns to the rioting crucible that once held a mighty empire.

****

“Entrapta, are the bots ready?”

“Prepared and in position to begin preliminary scan of planet number 6721, known locally as Ariabos. Ooh, the data, the unique ecosystem, the- focus, Entrapta! It’s people saving time.” Released from the belly of Darla, hovering delicately in the stratosphere, two iridescent shapes come hurtling towards the verdant plains at the heart of Felin. Once collision occurs, the shapes make light work of the grassy fields and rolling hills that stretch out before Felin Castle. As they close in on the outline of the castle, two details become very apparent to the hastily dubbed ‘Awesome Etherian Rescue Strike Team’. First, that the once prominent towers have been reduced to rubble, and second, that the grass and other wildlife close to the castle and surrounding settlements have been scorched. Not much better can be said of those settlements, and the complete desolation of Ariabos is slowly dawning on everyone on Darla’s ship. Glimmer lets out a gasp, while Bow remains behind his girlfriend, comforting her despite his own shock. “Preliminary search of the central area of power concentration on P dash 6721 has revealed… complete destruction. No life identified. No- wait, there is a single heat signature emanating from just outside the castle. Marcus approaching cautiously for observation.”

“You called the robot Marcus?” Bow turns to Entrapta, his eyes only momentarily drawn from the horrors on screen.

“It’s a perfectly fitting nam-”

“Will you all focus!” Glimmer pulls everyone back into the moment, her short temper the least of her issues right now. What about Kassi, or Gaman, or Alei- that can’t be a good train of

thought. She should focus on the mission ahead, in the immediate moment. Entrapta drags her into that place with her timely commentary.

"Signature appears to belong to a slight individual devoid of any Empire markings. She appears emotionally fragile but otherwise unharmed. No visible weapons or any-" Glimmer launches herself forward to get a close look at the screen.

"That's Alei! Come on, we have to go get her!"

"Glimmer, who is-"

"I'll explain on the way, now hurry!" Glimmer moves to grab the strike team and teleport, remembers that is not an option, and simply dashes out the ship door, staff in hand, Bow and the others trailing behind.

Out on the plains, Ariabos' desolation is immediate and terrifying. No life has remained on this part of the planet, and, according to Entrapta's other bots now on the other side of the world, this destruction is not unique. She relays this information to the team as they make their mad dash across to Alei, Glimmer becoming increasingly worried about the whereabouts of the revolution. Once again forcing herself into the moment, Glimmer yells at the figure in the distance, hoping that Alei recognises her voice and figure well enough. "Alei! It's me! Glimmer!" No response comes at first, but on the other side of the plains Alei looks up and sees her lucky salvation. She has wandered almost without thinking, too tired to run anymore, but when she sees Glimmer, hears her shrieking, her legs regain that burst of energy to run towards her with open arms.

"Glimmer! You came back. For me."

"Not just you. The whole planet, it's… what happened here?"

"The revolution fought harder than anyone expected, but the Empress- she scorched the earth and went into hiding. Food is hard to find, any remaining loyalists have been instructed to kill

on sight. I joined the revolution early, after what you said to me. But I couldn't leave- *her* . I was just underneath the castle. It's heavily fortified. There's no easy way in." Alei talks calmly through tears, a practiced skill. The strike team are stunned into silence, as is Entrapta, listening in through the headpieces.

"Alei, I'm so sorry. Did Meora not…"

"No, she's alive. She wouldn't come with me. It's okay." Glimmer returns to embrace her unlikely friend as the others watch on, tears forming in Bow's eyes.

Frosta, surprisingly, drags the group back to the harsh reality of their mission. "If what Alei says is true, then there's no point waiting for the Empress to surrender. We have to go in ourselves, with force!" Bow turns to chide Frosta before realising that she is right, at least about the time constraints of their mission.

"The revolution has fought harder than anyone should ever have to. We owe it to them to complete this mission no matter what," Glimmer exclaims, finding her strength again. The team, accompanied by Alei, moves silently towards the castle, reaching a back entrance that Alei promises is the easiest way in without announcing their presence too early. Scorpia hoists the others one by one into the tunnel, everyone quickly realising that this entrance smelled awful for a reason. They move silently, trying to block out the worst of the stench, Alei directing from the back of the group. Everyone has become aware of her fragility as their mission continues: the sniffling and shaking, combined with her slight form and lack of weaponry, lead Scorpia to hover behind her at the back of their convoy, an awfully familiar feeling appearing as she protects an emotionally damaged catgirl. The silence remains as they surface in the castle bathrooms, crawling out of the sewers cleaner than would be expected but still smelling awful. Bow catches himself before retching at the closeness of his girlfriend, a very close call considering her temper. Frosta dusts herself down and moves to batter down the bathroom door, but Bow grabs her ice-covered fist in the nick of time. "I know you wanna hit stuff, but can we hold it on the property damage until

someone attacks us?" Frosta looks disappointed but nods and retracts the ice. Putting on their stealthiest face, the five move out of the now-reeking bathroom and into an ornate corridor.

"Hey, Entrapta, where the hell are we? Any castle schematics?" Glimmer yell-murmurs into her earpiece.

"Good news! One of my bots has already mapped out the floor plan. Head to your left and through the enormous double doors, very hard to miss actually."

"Gotcha." Glimmer signals to her group and they turn down a particularly well decorated hallway, the walls coated in golds and purples, languid designs stretching from ceiling to floor. It would be stunning, were it not the decor of a murderous dictator's home. In fact, the whole place reeks of privilege and mistreatment, even the fact it was so quiet and untouched in here despite the travesties outside. Before her thoughts can run any further, the group reaches their end point. The doors are, indeed, enormous. Lavished in gold and patterned timber, stretching up to the high ceiling covered in tapestry and art. Bow draws himself away after realising just how suspiciously empty this castle is, and how unusually well their stealth has gone so far. "Hey, guys, doesn't it seem a bit weird how we're just standing in front of the Empress' chamber and there are no guards or anything?"

"You're right, that *is* weird!" says Scorpia with a little too much enthusiasm, as usual.

"Keep it d-"

"Uh, Bow?!" Right on cue, the doors of the chamber begin to open, and the stern visage of the Empress appears in everyone's eyelines. Frosta restrains the urge to charge and punch her, seeing the mass of guards at either side of the throne.

"Sorry guys," whispers Scorpia.

"It's okay, Scorpia," Entrapta's voice comes awfully loud through all their earpieces, breaking the terse silence in the chamber. "She

was going to open that door anyway.”

“And you didn’t tell us?” Glimmer returns to her angry whisper voice.

“It would have changed no variables. And it’s more fun this way!”

“Ahem! I am Bow of the Etherian Galactic Peacekeeping Force, and we have… broken into your castle with the information that you, as Empress, have mistreated and abused your people. As such, we are asking you right now to step down from the throne and allow the revolution to take power of the Felin Empire under guidance from Etheria, or we will use force.” Bow sneaks a sly grin at Frosta after that last part.

“So, you’ve rebranded? Galactic Peacekeeping does sound a whole lot nicer than Empire, doesn’t it? Shame it’s all the same. This is a coup, from a terrorist organisation with no real claim to the throne, and my Empire, my divine right, is not about to bend to the whim of some power tripping Queen and her boyfriend, let alone those degenerate rebels.”

“I’m not some power tripping Queen, I’m Glimmer of Etheria, and you have no right to that throne! Kassi Kangelene had her family murdered by your regime, a royal family no less, and they should be granted the ‘divine right’ you think you deserve!” Glimmer moves proudly in front of Bow and takes charge, even managing to sow doubt on the faces of the Felin guards. A familiar voice cuts through the Empress’ silent fury.

“Alei, why are you here?”

“Meora! I had to help the Queen… I’m sorry.” Their tender expressions cross the infinite metres of the throne room.

“So you came back, traitor?” The Empress’ voice is brimming with spite.

Alei chooses to ignore her. “Please, Meora. You heard what she did to the royal family. You never had to choose her. You can

come with us.”

“Meora, you must remain at my side. The guards will handle your traitorous friend and her accomplices.” At the center of this verbal tug of war, Meora is quiet and downcast. The room awaits her first move. Then Alei steps forwards and takes her by the hand, a gentle action that prompts an eager guard to force her back into the strike team’s embrace, and Glimmer responds in kind. Suddenly, Meora and Alei are in a sea of bodies, a violent brawl. Alei catches the eye of the Empress as she slips away through a back door, and grabs Meora’s hand in the tussle before she can turn and follow.

“Please, Meora. For me. You promised to treat me well.” Meora’s eyes are wide, her body shaking. She turns herself to face Alei. The brawl rages behind their static forms, Glimmer’s yelling and the fizzing of arrows suddenly a tranquil soundtrack. In an all too finite moment, Meora leans to kiss Alei and, feeling the soft return of pressure on her lips, turns down the well lit corridor behind her, in the wake of the Empress.

No Dream Pt.1

Chapter Summary

> Adora struggles in the Wastes but finds a friendly face. Catra gets unlucky.

Chapter Notes

> and so they reconcile
> hell yea catradora stuff that isnt sad dream nonsense!!!
> this one is fun and angsty how about that

Adora, for once, is rapt with thoughts about someone other than Catra. The soft, tortured face of a child dealing with the world, the costume in tatters, the quiet sobbing in time with hers on the empty streets. He-Man seemed like a pretty great kid, and a small part of Adora wants to forget about her dedication to Catra and come crawling back to Brightmoon with a new protégé. Of course, her legs do not stop moving. The surroundings flash by, the tree cover fading as Adora stumbles across the end of the Whispering Woods. The vast plains in front of her are empty, searingly hot and bright orange. Turning her eyes away from the expanse and the sun blinding her to the west, Adora notices a cluster of buildings and returns to her mindless pace, her boots barely finding purchase on the soft sand.

Her head spinning from the intense heat, Adora clings to a shack on the outskirts of town, seeking shelter and sustenance. Though her conscious state is hanging on just barely, she manages to take a lay of the land. Her eyes catch on a bustling bar and a figure leaving it. One with cascading white hair, and arms that the gayest parts of Adora's brain have never quite forgotten. Though her throat is dry, she forces out a cry directed towards that familiar figure. "Huntara! Hey, wait up!"

"Oh, it's you. Hey, blondie." Adora stumbles across the town centre and, overshooting a conveniently placed handrail outside

the bar, walks directly into Huntara. “Are you drunk or something?”

“No, I’m- just been walking for a while. Tired. You know, exploring… stuff. Hi.”

“You’re definitely not in the right state for the Wastes. Hell, I’m surprised you made it this far. I’ll take you back to my place and then you can tell me exactly what the fuck you are doing away from Brightmoon looking like a crazy person.”

“Sounds… yea- woo. Just one second.” Adora passes out in Huntara’s arms, her world going black too quickly to register.

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Waking up sprawled in a rough cot, in what looks like a once-normal living room ravaged by every creature in the Wastes with teeth, Adora’s mind is full again. Echoes from her time unconscious dominate her headspace, the voices of Catra and Shadoweaver hauntingly familiar.

I didn’t want you to come back!

Look how much pain she causes you.

Glimmer’s voice, too, quieter and more distant.

You killed my mother!

Even Bow, the quietest of them all.

If you really let one disagreement get in the way of a friendship, then-

“Hey, blondie. You awake?”

“Uh- yea. I think so.” Adora does feel awake, now that Huntara’s voice has cut through the flashes.

"Honestly, you shouldn't really be alive. I would imagine some sort of She-Ra magic kept you going there because what looked like weeks of constant sun exposure without protection, bruises and cuts everywhere, most of them infected, would be enough to at least put someone in the hospital for a very long time."

"I think I was just determined. At least, I don't feel She-Ra, right now."

"Ha! You *are* an idiot if you think *determination* could carry just anyone through the Wastes without any preparation." Adora just sits up and smiles at her old friend. Huntara turns from her cooking and returns the smile, lending Adora a strong grasp to help her up. Her stance is wobbly at first, but she puts an assured right foot behind her frail body, and suddenly feels far better than she ever had struggling through the Etherian wilds alone. "So, you gonna tell me what you're doing out here alone?"

"I'm… looking for someone. But I came very unprepared, kinda because I had to, or Glimmer and Bow would get all protective and I can't have them ruining this mission, not that they have in the past but- but this is different-"

"Woah! Slow down there, blondie. Just, tell me who you're looking for and I'm sure I can help."

"It's, uh- Catra. The pretty one with a tail and different coloured eyes and a very, *very* hot smile. Who took over your gang."

"I thought you guys were fucking? After the whole Horde Prime thing, all anyone would talk about here was how Catra had gone soft, living in Brightmoon with She-Ra, and I can see that I shouldn't have brought this up, and oh god- please don't start crying!" Too late for Huntara, Adora drops into her arms, this time conscious but a snivelling wreck of emotions and repeating the word Catra ad infinitum. "Hey, hey, it's uh- it'll be ok? It wasn't that bad a fight, right?"

In between sobs, Adora forces herself to explain her sadness: "She left me! Just ranted for like 5 minutes and ran away! God, I'm such a wreck."

"Oh… dear. I'm so sorry, Adora."

"I mean, we didn't *officially* break up, she just… no one knows where she is. But I'm finding her now. I need to- to tell her something important."

"Well, you're lucky the Wastes have been quiet lately, because you'll need me to survive any longer out there. I'm sure we can find a lead in town, but you need your rest, and a new outfit, before we go anywhere." Huntara scoops up Adora, who thankfully has stopped crying, and places her back in the scratchy cot. Her eyes shut quickly, and her sleep is undisturbed.

Crimson Waste mornings are bright and stuffy. Adora awakens covered in a film of sweat, and leaps out of bed to the detriment of her still sore skin and head. Huntara is already awake, packing essentials into a canvas bag. She turns, smiles slightly, and hands Adora a complex, slim garment with dark grey padding connecting areas of tan fabric. "You can undress back there, put this on over your underwear and it'll make life in the desert easy." Adora nods and, in Huntara's bathroom, slips on the bodysuit. The fabric is breathable despite its tightness, and Adora wonders why Brightmoon didn't have any of these for past trips into the Wastes. She walks back into the main room and Huntara throws her the canvas bag, now full with supplies. "I'll take you as far as possible without Catra seeing me. Finding her won't be the issue, but you have to talk to her on your own."

"I know."

"You're gonna do great, blondie. Now, let's get tracking."

For whatever perverse reason, hunting down Catra helps Adora take her mind off Catra. The minutiae of exploring the town for tracks and claw marks, the terse conversations with townsfolk, it's

all very logical and routine. Thinking about Catra always was an illogical process, knowing that she only wanted to cause pain and seeing only fond memories anyway. Adora can lose herself in activity without morality, without the anxiety that comes as part and parcel of the whole She-Ra thing. The search is beginning to look fruitless, as Huntara becomes less calm with each mismatching claw mark or oblivious resident, until a shadowed, scaly figure, the proud owner of a half-broken shack, reports seeing someone of Catra's type stowing away in her house a few nights ago. Adora is pulled away from her work induced reverie at the mention of a slender form with cat-like ears, and turns to stare down this eerie helper. "Did you see her after you kicked her out?"

"Depends."

"Depends on what?" Huntara steps closer into the conversation, her size and reputation a reminder of who holds the power.

"Well- I only saw her for a few seconds. She looked like she was crying, then she started to stare up at the moon, and when I turned away, she must have run. Can't have gone far though." Adora furrows her brow, the sparkle of an idea beginning to appear.

"Catra always went to high places when she was upset, or thoughtful. If we head to the top of the valley and follow where the moon goes down, we might at least find her tracks."

"Good thinking, blondie." They walk off into the evening, heading up the wooden struts at the edges of the valley.

"You know, you shouldn't intimidate your people like that."

"What? We got the information we needed, and it's not like I hurt the guy. It's a perfectly fine persuasion tactic."

"I could have turned into She-Ra and done the same, but there wasn't any reason to."

"Well, we got what we wanted, and he got to walk home unharmed. I really don't see the issue."

"It's not very princess-like."

"Gah! I never was a princess. I just look after this dump. In my own way. Mind your business, eh, blondie?"

"Sure, sure." Adora is downcast at first, but turns to see Huntara grinning. One punch of affection (and likely bruise) later, the two have surfaced from the valley. This end of the town is buried deep, the valley stretching far underground where before it had barely been discernible from the surroundings. It's a long way down. Huntara begins the search for tracks quietly, giving Adora space to contemplate the place where the ghost of her love had likely resided not too long ago.

Catra's tracks are concealed by dust. She turns to find the desert creeping over her footprints, and frowns involuntarily. What, does she want to be found? The Wastes have not been kind to her in the days since leaving the valley. Time has passed, and she has become weak and frail. Melog has been hunting, but their skin is dry and voice quiet. The sun goes down, and it stays hot. The sun comes up, and it gets hotter. She is hungry a lot, thirsty more often, ignoring the spines of cacti in search of the water they hold. Two cuts have become infected, and her ribs still hurt from the rough landing when she was kicked out.

Adora finds very little at the rim of the valley. Huntara has pointed out a few stray prints or claw marks, equally likely to be other locals or the wildlife as Catra. As they scour the edge, crossing a rickety wooden bridge in search of tracks on the other side, Adora ricochets in her mind between futility and desire.

I didn't want you to come back.

I always have!

Took you long enough to show up.

Not because I like you.

The phrases flash and sparkle in her mind. Catra's voice is increasingly amorphous, like it was during the war. Sometimes, it's the gentle squeak of her as a child, sometimes the confident rasp of her as Hordak's second in command.

Catra is breaking down. More specifically, her battered body is fading under the sun, and her vision is swarming with dots and flashes. In between the torrent, her surroundings are starting to look familiar again. Has she been walking in circles? That rock to the left, marred by a shadowy crack down its centre. The moon is rising again, ahead of her. It lights up more of the scarred ground, the scattered rocks. It's all so familiar. The canyon ahead of her, once behind her, is a stab wound on the earth, and two figures tend to it in the night, the same night that Catra stands alone in, believing that she is going to die.

Adora is closer than ever to giving up. Nothing concrete, nothing *Catra* , has appeared to her or Huntara as the night has closed in. A torrent of memories overpowers her perception, the surroundings fading away.

You're such an idiot.

You promise?

Not yet, okay?

Hey, Adora.

Hey Adora!

Adora!

Adora.

"Adora!" She spins, jolting her tired body with the effort. The cry, cutting through the unending cycle of memory and pain, is hoarse and weak, and as Catra's form closes in, Adora notices how frail

she looks. Each foot that strikes the earth does so with less conviction than the one before it, her run becoming a pained walk, and soon after she collapses.

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Catra awakens in a messy, dilapidated home, curled up in a soft cot. Adora is staring her down, her eyes filled with too many emotions to even attempt processing. Catra's brain is a fog, memories of her stumble across the desert towards the subject of her twin love and hate a vague singularity. Adora sits up, standing close to the tall, shadowed figure in the main room, visible through rather pointless curtains. Catra expects her to speak, but gets only silence. The figure speaks, and Catra recognises her voice quick enough in her drowsy state. "You were beaten to shit by the desert, so to speak. We expected to find you, well, not unconscious on the floor, so now I have to either leave blondie alone with someone who was dying a few hours ago, or get in the way of whatever this-" Huntara gestures to the terse emptiness between the undefined rooms- "is. For now, you should just sleep." Catra is too tired to not comply.

Some long hours pass, her sleep now disturbed, the cot scratchier than it had felt when she first awoke. Sometimes her eyes will flash open, and she will catch sight of Adora, her figure illuminated, seemingly torn between the quiet, softly lit bedroom and the harsh light of the main room. Catra sees her face once, her expression half regret, half relief. Like back in the Horde, where she would give Catra her food whenever Shadoweaver went too far. There would always be a flash, lines on the soft skin of her face, that belied her selflessness. Catra never ate much anyway. "Idiot," Catra murmurs, and drifts once more to sleep.

Adora almost falls asleep on the wall connecting the two rooms. Huntara had put up a curtain as Adora walked in, cradling Catra's bruised body. Now she hates the divide, hates with all her heart that she can't bring herself to be in the same room as someone she loves. At first, her attention was only for Catra's sleeping form, but as time passes she loses grip on reality. She jolts out of

her near sleep, and pretends to busy herself, moving quietly into the backroom, stripping out of her sweat coated desert bodysuit and washing away the worst of the sand and dirt. She knows this will wake Catra again, she has seen the restless sleep play out for hours, but she doesn't care. When she returns to the non-space between both rooms, the cot is empty. The small window above it is open. Adora bolts.

Half dressed in casual wear, feet bare and sore over the hot earth, a half full canvas backpack thrown over one shoulder, Adora persues.

Catra hears the rapid footsteps all too late, her mind in the wrong places. She turns, sees blonde and blue flashing, and runs.

The desert stretches on. Adora could have never run this far in this sun on her way to the Wastes, but leaving it, finding *her* , gives her enough strength.

Catra notices the greenery on the horizon and almost slows. It would be terrible to head back there. Melog is nowhere to be found - they vanished during her return to the valley - so she would have no chance of escaping the villagers. Not without a fight. Adora is getting closer. How is she so fast?

Adora's legs strike the ground harder and harder. As her body should be giving up, each step becomes full with determination.

Catra clears her head, for now, and focuses on each heartbeat, each sensation of the ground against her paws. Too fast.

Adora feels a glow as the green horizon becomes more than just a grand distant thing.

Catra almost grinds to a halt as the dirt becomes grass.

Adora spots her salvation in a village to the east.

Catra cannot forge a way through the growing shrubbery; her fastest route is to the village.

Adora sees the welcoming embrace of thatched roofs.

Catra sees a familiar face, again.

They both stop. He-Man guards the gate, villagers in badly-hewn armour, carrying pitchforks.

Catra turns away and sees the greatest horror in the universe. Adora is smiling, and in the reflection in a puddle, Catra finds herself smiling too.

"Hey, Catra."

Catra forces the smile away. She is surrounded by forest, the town to her back, and a tall, terrifyingly fast and somehow *glowing* girl in front of her, grinning like their past means nothing. On closer inspection it is a sad smile, her face open, eyes downturned.

"Why did you follow me, Adora? I ran away. What don't you get?"

"You stumbled across the desert and shouted my name before collapsing in front of me. I'm not the only disaster here, Catra." They both almost laugh, but something about how Adora says her name makes Catra seize up.

"Always the hero. Always having to save me, from me." Her words drip with imagined spite.

"I don't have to do anything. I ran away from my responsibility, from She-Ra, to find you. I wanted to find you."

"That's a lie. Glimmer and Bow must have come with you."

"Have *you* seen them? You think I *teleported* here?" Catra was wrong there - and of course she was - and she is wrong to reject this, wrong to feel that urge in her legs, wrong to find so much pain on the surface of Adora's expression.

"Please don't fight for me anymore, Adora. I'm not worth it."

“No. You’re right, you *aren’t* worth it.” Catra turns her head upward in shock; but Adora is not done. “But you deserve it, and I deserve it.”

“What the fuck is the difference?”

“No one can measure the value of your life, Catra, not even me. But people should do good to you regardless.” The clearing is silent. “I should do good to you, regardless.” The distance between Catra and Adora starts to get smaller. The townsfolk have all gone home. It’s a nice evening, Catra thinks, nicer now with tears streaming down her face, with some of the pain fading from the lines in Adora’s expression. The air is hot, and the humidity feels heavy, all of a sudden.

It’s heavy.

A weight settles back on Catra’s chest, and it is not the air.

No Dream Pt.2

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra wander home through the Whispering Woods.

Chapter Notes

WOOOOOOOOOOOO FLUFF AND GAY

"Now come home. For me, Catra, and for you." A torrent of emotions burns through Catra's brain, fire swelling in her chest. The humidity is making her sweat more, mixing with her tears, her fur becoming damp and flattened. Adora's words seem to spiral and delay in her head, dragging the guilt out from hiding places with their movement.

You deserve it.

Have you ever considered that the reason might be you?

You drive them away.

The reason might be you.

You drive them away.

You love me?

Wow.

You-

It might be-

Drive them away-

You.

She is breathing heavily. Her chest rises and falls, the burning coming in waves now. “I’d like that.” Catra smiles, and then her whole world is the piercing blue of Adora’s eyes, and then it’s black, and the last thing she feels are her legs giving way, and only a moment of falling, and then she is caught.

Adora doesn’t go back to Huntara’s. It’s too far, and she doesn’t want to make Catra feel trapped. Instead, she carries Catra’s warm, heavy body through the dense foliage, pushing apart the vines to reveal the same sanctuary that had kept the rebellion safe all those months ago. Horde Prime’s damage reshaped the landscape; now the open field sways and dips, but the forest has claimed what land is jagged and left bare a soft open space. She lays Catra down in its centre, and thinks what it would feel like to float down on this scene, to find the symmetry in the body resting amidst a sea of green, to map out from above the way she melds with nature. To find her up close, a golden flicker of nothingness tousling her hair and turning the tear stains iridescent. It would be nice to float away. Pain is never worth it. But Adora deserves this moment, decides the forest, deserves to see from every angle the soft creature brought into safety by her selfish hand. Pain is never worth it, not when this is so fleeting. So it lasts, and it continues to last, and Adora continues to float on but never away, spiralling around the frail figure of Catra again, learning to understand her. There are no quick flashes, there is no darkness. She chose to stay. So it lasts, and in Adora’s mind the painful linear flow of time starts to bend, and every moment is not a consequence of the one prior but now of what follows, the loop breaking at the seams. Eventually, in Roman fashion, the paths of Adora’s memory lead back here. The truest present. A moment that never stops lasting, not even when Catra stirs and her eyelids flutter and her right leg shifts ever so slightly, and doesn’t dare destroy the symmetry but instead builds beauty anew, and when Catra breathes in a little heavier than before Adora thinks she knows the meaning of everything, and she does know the only meaning that matters, and the forest tells her they are mostly the same.

“Adora, stop staring at me, it’s creepy.” Catra is smiling. There isn’t ever a pleasant moment broken by a smile.

So Adora smiles back, and says, “You were sleeping for a while, and I wanted to make sure you were ok.”

Catra doesn’t respond how she should. She just keeps on smiling, and holds onto Adora’s hand, and they stand together.

Both girls spin to face each other, take a whiff of the air in unison, and burst into laughter. “You smell *awful* !” yells Catra in between giggles, while Adora just gasps for air. They almost step apart, but Adora starts holding onto Catra as her laughter fades, and so Catra returns the favour. Catra sinks into Adora’s arms, letting the familiarity of their shape accept her, and so they rest in the half shade in the forest clearing.

The journey home is long and slow. Catra spent the last of her energy running away from Adora through the woods, and now allows Adora to drag her gently eastward, towards Brightmoon. They talk sometimes, smile often, and occasionally let the beauty of the woods speak for themselves. Catra watches the way their legs move in time, their footsteps close but not awkward, transfixed by this subconscious organisation but not enough to sabotage it.

She focuses on the movements of Adora’s calf muscles, those tiny adjustments and strong strides carrying her forwards. She focuses on the earth, the grass and dirt marred only slightly in their wake. She focuses on her own bare feet, half stepping in lazy synchronization, and only too late realises that Adora is saying something.

“Uh- what was that, babe?” Adora doesn’t respond, and when Catra looks up at her, she is crying with a smile still on her face. “You ok?”

“You called me babe-”

“Is that- should I not have done that?” Catra stammers. God, she’s already catching Adora’s nervousness again.

“It’s fine. It’s, uh, really great actually.”

“I thought I could try a new- what are they called, pet names? Is that what Sparkles called them?”

“I think so.”

“Well, yea. Since this- is a thing again. If you want.” She really is a disaster. But Adora has stopped crying, and her smile has gotten warmer.

“I do. I really do want to, Catra.” They cry together, this time.

“Do you seriously forgive me, Adora?”

“I forgave you before. It’s not that hard.” Catra can’t muster the courage to believe that, but she knows when Adora is lying, and the confidence in her eyes in that moment might be enough.

The forest passes, as it tends to do when on the move, and Catra starts to take notice of all the wildlife hidden just beyond subconscious perception in the woods. Rather than zone out and face the horribly cheesy consequences again, Catra voices her thoughts. “The woods are really pretty, right?”

“Huh? Yea- sure,” Adora mumbles.

“You idiot, were you zoned out?”

“You were too, like not even 10 minutes ago!” Adora pushes Catra lightly, and Catra, despite her aching bones, shoves back in kind. Soon enough, they are rolling in the grass, nearly veering from the path, Adora’s hands free and loose. Catra holds onto Adora the moment before they roll into a tree, stopping them both, faces inches from each other. It’s quiet again, and there is a nice breeze tousling Catra’s hair. She leans in, and kisses Adora as gently as she can muster, parting their lips before proximity gives either of them any ideas. “I missed that.” Catra’s voice is breathy and soft, softer than she would ever wish it.

“Wow. Me too.” Adora knows better than to drag a moment out, and pulls Catra up. They grin breathlessly at each other and begin

their walk again, rounding a corner mere minutes later to find the glory of Brightmoon Castle dominating their once insular, contained forest visage. It shimmers in the afternoon sun, and Catra thinks there is something so important in the rays of light and the way they traverse the space to caress the river as it gently flows, searches for meaning in the iridescence of the runestone, and turns to find her answers in Adora’s wide eyes, as bright as they have ever been. Or maybe, they never stopped shining.

This Must Be The Place

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra return to Brightmoon, until an unexpected message sends them out into the stars.

Chapter Notes

catradora being fluffy and then some plot. next chapter is gonna have some full best friend squad action and even sappier nonsense

"Hey, Adora?"

"Huh-"

"Should we go inside?" Catra turns, smiles, and points an open palm at Adora, who is still staring up at Brightmoon like she has never seen it before. After feeling the warmth of another's hand in hers, Catra begins to run, laughing and carefree down the hallway, Adora pulled behind. She almost doesn't feel her tiredness, not until Adora pulls Catra aside to take a breath herself, and Catra realises she wants nothing more than to lay down, preferably somewhere comfy, for the rest of eternity. She looks into Adora's bright eyes and somehow a pleasant understanding fills them both. Adora leads Catra this time, back down the hallway and into a bedroom blessed by evening sunlight. Adora has not changed the bed.

"This is the comfiest I've been in weeks."

"And whose fault is that?" Adora's tone is teasing, but Catra feels a twinge of guilt regardless. She turns to face Adora, her head propped up on her cheek.

"I will never not be sorry for leaving, Adora. I think, since we never really talked about what happened during the war, I still kinda wanted to punish you for leaving the Horde. And that's

awful, and I can't really forgive myself for that. Or for denying myself this bed." Catra knows better than to completely kill the mood.

"Nothing in my life could have been a punishment if it's ended up like this," and Adora gestures to the pillows, blankets, and the half-naked body of the woman she can't help but love.

"You are the sappiest human being on the face of the earth."

"Only with you, darling."

"Did you just wink- oh, if Sparkles saw you like this, she would have a fit. 'What did you do with my Adora, wahhhh!' Wait. Shit. Sparkles! Where is she!" Catra goes wide-eyed and grabs Adora, but only gets an amused smirk in return.

"Look at you, caring about Glimmer." Catra's shock turns to embarrassment and she instinctively pushes Adora's giggling face away, partially out of fear that *that* smile will make her blush.

"Gah! It's not that- ok, fine, I do worry about Sparkles *sometimes* but if you *ever* tell her that, I'll kill you."

"Whatever you say, darling."

"Can we just go find her? Or at least Arrow Boy." Adora nods and grabs Catra's hand, leading them out of the bedroom door and towards the throne room. They stop to check Glimmer's bedroom, Catra peering through a crack in the door to find only empty space. She turns away and shakes her head to a disapproving Adora, who is frowning. Catra scowls as if to say *what?* , and Adora's half-teasing glare somehow communicates the whole invasion-of-privacy thing that Catra had struggled with before in Brightmoon. Catra turns away, more ashamed than she would like to admit, but Adora tightens her grip on her hand and pulls them both down the corridor.

****

Thankfully, the throne room is not empty. Micah sits, clearly bored out of his mind, on the throne, his bead closely shaven and formal clothing absent in place of loosely draped robes. He smiles with wide eyes at Adora's entrance, and nearly falls off the throne when she pulls Catra through the doorway. "A-Adora, and- hello Catra! It's… good to see you both, here, now."

"Hi Micah!" chirps Catra a little too suddenly, desperate to avoid any awkward discussions about her prior absence with people who aren't Adora.

"Hello, your majest-" Adora starts to bow but is cut off by a tight hug, that Catra watches amused until Micah gestures her in. The squeeze is suffocating, and horrible, and almost as warm as Adora's bed. Not to mention being close to Adora is always pleasant for Catra, no matter the situation.

"It is so wonderful to see you both alive and well. I won't press you with questions about your little… trip right now, I'm sure you're very tired, but don't expect the same from my daughter. Oh! That reminds me. Glimmer wanted me to tell you that her, Bow, and some of the Princesses have formally disbanded the Etherian Empire and are currently away on their first mission as the Galactic Peacekeeping Force, freeing Ariabos from a dictatorship." Adora smiles, her warm demeanour somewhat placating Catra's confusion. "And some news for you, Catra. A very nice lady named- Hunter, I think? She sent a message to Brightmoon, recently, explaining she has been looking after some sort of cat that she suspects might be yours." Catra perks up suddenly, and turns wide eyed to Adora.

"Adora, we forgot Melog!"

"Oh! Shit, Catra, aren't you two like, connected? How did you completely forget they exist?"

"Hey, don't blame me! I mean, it is entirely my fault, but- ugh, shut up." Catra smirks slightly and pushes away at Adora's smug, knowing face, both irritated and weirdly enamoured by this odd

dynamic. Since when was Adora so good at teasing? "So do we have to go get them?" She tries to pull the conversation back on track.

"Well, Huntra-"

"It's Huntara," corrects Adora.

"Huntara, right, she said she would come by and drop it- them off. Supposedly she has nothing better to do, which doesn't seem right because I'm pretty sure Glimmer said she was the ruler of the Crimson Waste, and lord knows that place still needs some work- but anyway, I'm rambling. You girls get some rest, Melog will get here shortly, and when Glimmer and the rest of the Peacekeeping Force get home we can all have a party."

"A party?" Catra frowns.

"Well, of course! To celebrate you and Adora returning, and the successful liberation of Ariabos."

"You're pretty confident in Glimmer."

"And you aren't, Adora?"

"I mean… I didn't leave on the best of terms. Again. I want it to be *right* again, but I need to speak to her. And Bow. Properly, and listen to what they have to say."

"Well, I can't see anything wrong with that. Glimmer has grown a lot since the war, as I'm sure you were aware, and I think since deciding to disband the empire she has really dedicated herself to the idea of granting people peace. And you, Adora, are someone who I know she would want to enjoy that peace with. And maybe even you, Catra." Micah gives an unexpected sideways glance and smirks at Catra, who freezes for a second before returning the look with all the sass she can muster.

"Thank you, Micah. It's good to have someone like you here in Brightmoon. Me and Catra should head back to our room, she's

starting to look real tired." Adora turns and grabs Catra's hand gently. As soon as they are out of earshot and Micah's fond farewell has echoed into silence, Catra spins to face her girlfriend. "And how exactly am I starting to look tired?"

"Did you want to get into bed with me or not, silly?" A new nickname, a clever retort, a knowing smile. Who was this Adora? Of course, it was still Adora. Who knew all Catra's tells, her movements and motives, spoke to her with a lightness of heart that filled Catra with immutable joy, and had now apparently got really good at flirting. Well, it was only fair for her to respond in kind.

"Wow, I didn't know you were that horny. Even when talking to the King! How *naughty* , Adora." Catra lets the words roll on her tongue, and turns to see her prize. Adora, looking up and away, clearly flustered and glowing red and blue. "I win!"

"It's not a competition, Catra." Adora's words are chiding but her smile is wide regardless. She spins away from Catra and bolts towards the bedroom, almost colliding with a Brightmoon guard who growls before turning back in surprise, clearly only just realising who nearly ran into her. Catra pursues with haste, darting past Adora as they both crash through the doorway. She leaps a good two metres onto the bed, sending pillows spiralling away and forming a perfect crater for Adora to bomb into, laughing and grinning once in Catra's close proximity again. They both come to a near-silence in unison, the twin sounds of heavy breathing suddenly all there is to fill up the space in Adora's bedroom. Adora feels herself floating away again, hitchhiking on a sensation up into the sky to find the twin curls of two girls in bed together reflected amidst blanket folds and strewn pillows. It's a pink and vibrant scene, the brown spiral of Catra's tail and the blonde chaos of Adora's hair mirrored dissidents in a perfect system. The moment forms itself eternal in Adora's heart before she is pulled back to the linear by a gentle caress.

"Kiss me?" Catra's voice is husky.

“I really want to.” And so they kiss more than once. They press foreheads and breathe in each other often, and Adora feels Catra’s hands around her again and again, and they will fall asleep in each other’s arms in every life sometimes, which is probably enough.

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Perversely, they wake up and it’s near evening. The castle is full of shadows, but nothing nasty is concealed. Adora is quite sure of that. She glances at Catra, breathing gently in her sleep, and turns to find the reason for her nap being broken. Her tracker pad is blinking bright red, flashing on the ceiling in the half light. Weary eyed and barely awake, she grabs the tracker pad and sits forward gently. Catra turns around anyway and murmurs something to Adora, lazily flopping her arm into the space where Adora had been laying. “What was that?” says Adora, her voice hushed.

“I said,” grumbles Catra, now clearly more awake, “what the hell are you doing? Never interrupt a good nap.”

“So you *do* like sleeping with me.” Adora pulls her attention from the tracker pad and grins at Catra.

“Shut up. You make a good pillow.” They go quiet, Catra silently admiring the muscular silhouette of her girlfriend in the evening light. “What are you even looking at?”

“A message came through just now. It was what woke me up. It has some sort of SOS encoding but I can’t seem to actually load the contents.”

“Pass it here.” Adora complies and hands the pad over to Catra, sat up next to her on the bed. “Hmm. It’s definitely corrupted, probably something wrong with the transmitter at the sender’s end. But, we have literally no way of ever knowing, so just come back to bed, okay?”

“But what if it’s Glimmer?”

"The likelihood of it actually being Sparkles, of the millions of people who would send a message to the tracker pad owned by *intergalactic hero* She Ra, are basically non-existent-"

"Girls! Come quick, it's Glimmer!" Adora shoots a smug glance at Catra and transforms as quickly as she can before running, Catra in hand, towards the source of the cry.

Micah is standing breathless over a receiver terminal that had been scavenged from Horde Prime after the war. It had given the fledgling Etherian Empire galactic communication capacity, but now, with Micah frantically pushing buttons and murmuring over it, it seems more an annoyance than anything. "Uhh, Micah, what is going on?" Catra is the first to interrupt Micah's rather crazy-looking behaviour.

"Oh. Good. You two are here! I just received a transmission from Glimmer that, I believe, pertains to her mission on Ariabos."

"We received the same transmission, your m- Micah, but we couldn't load the contents."

"Well, that's exactly my problem. This terminal is far superior technology to your tracker pad, so I could determine who was sending the message, and from where, as well as the SOS-priority encoding, but it could say anything and I would be none the wiser."

"So are we gonna plan a rescue mission?" Adora, in all her She-Ra glory, looks raring to go. Catra, dragging her mind out of the gutter, remembers that the 'save Glimmer' plan is quite a frequent occurrence, and winces at the bad memories.

"Adora, I love your enthusiasm, as always, but we have no idea about the situation on Ariabos besides the potential danger. Glimmer, Bow and the others could be bait for a trap designed to take out She-Ra," Micah then glances at Catra in that newly familiar half-knowing way, "or her girlfriend."

"It doesn't matter. We have to try."

“Adora, remember what-”

“No, you’re right, Catra. But I want to try. For my friends.”

“Uh, nice moment guys, but practically this is still going to be a nightmare. If Entrapta were here she could *maybe* work on unpicking this message but I have no idea what I’m doing, and even then we would have very little idea of what to expect.”

“It’s ok, Micah. Me and Catra…we’ve gone through worse. You stay here, keep the Castle safe and work on deciphering that message. You can send us a transmission if you get it deciphered while we’re on the- shit. We don’t have a ship.”

“I can help with that.” They all spin in unison to see Huntara, standing proud in the throne room doorway, Melog at her side.

“Hey Huntar-”

“MELOG!” Catra practically screams and bounds towards her briefly estranged companion, embracing them and murmuring a million apologies in a scene that baffles even Adora, while the other party simply purrs. Adora begins to giggle, at which point Catra lets go of Melog in shock at herself and blush-growls at her girlfriend. “Shut up! I only missed them because you get so boring. Idiot.”

“Sure, sure.” Adora, now back in her normal form after realising the lack of imminent danger, strolls up to the doorway, accepting a gentle kiss from Melog and a sudden embrace from Huntara in quick succession. “So Huntara,” squeezes out Adora, “you can help with our ship problem?”

“Recently, we unearthed a bunch of other First Ones ships around the area where Mara’s ship used to be. They aren’t as big or well equipped, but they’ll do the job for the two of you.”

“You could come with us?”

“No, it’s not my fight, not my place. I need to keep the Wastes under control. And besides, I wouldn’t want to third wheel the whole way.” Catra blushes visibly at that last comment, while Adora just stares on blankly.

“Well, we can travel with you to the ship, and say goodbye there.”

****

They make quick work of the journey to the Wastes, laying in the back of Huntara’s skiff, a vehicle she informs them is new and heavily modified just as they cross into the desert in the depths of night. Catra yawns and rests her head on Adora’s shoulder, tickling her face with a stray ear. “H-hey! You really don’t have much control over those ears, do you?”

“Oh, I do.” Catra smirks, but pulls the ear away from Adora’s face.

“Catra, can I ask you a question?”

“You just did, but sure.” She frowns and sits up slightly, meeting Adora’s wandering eyes.

“What *is* a ‘third wheel’?” Catra bursts out laughing, to Adora’s surprise and annoyance. “Hey, don’t laugh! It’s a serious question.” Her tone is embarrassed, and Catra notices quickly enough.

“Uh, it’s when someone is hanging out with a couple, and they sort of hover on the edge while the other two do… you know, romantic stuff.”

“Ohhhhh, I see now. Are we… too romantic?”

“Adora, you idiot. Don’t you want to be all lovey? You’re the sappy one.”

“I mean… yea, I do. I really do. Just, if it annoys everyone else, then-”

“Adora, remember? Let yourself be happy. I thought we had worked on this before I- oh.” Catra immediately regrets chastising Adora, but she shows no signs of acknowledgement other than pleading sadness.

“I know, Catra, I know. I’m sorry, I need to do bet-”

“No, you *want* to do better. And I’m sorry too. I shouldn’t be pushing you to make any more progress than you’ve already made.”

“You’re right. Who cares, right? Let’s be *double* romantic, and that’ll really show ‘em!”

“If you do that I might actually die.”

“Because you’re *soooo* in love with me?"

“What? Shut *up* , dummy!”

“So you’re not in love with me?”

“Oh, you are just being the most annoying today,” smirks Catra, but Adora doesn’t let up her pleading eyes.

“C’mon, you can say it, right? I’ll go first. I love you, Catra. I love pretty much everything about you. Your smile, your fur and ears and all the other parts of you that make you, you, I guess. I love how you just seem to know me so well, even when we argue or we’re apart. I love you, Catra.” Adora gets loud during her long winded confession, loud to the point of distracting Huntara, who shoots the two a warm smile and mercifully turns back to driving the skiff.

Catra whispers, “I love you,” and goes bright red.

Adora is shouting now, not annoyed but more like teasing. “You can’t say it! Not loudly, at least.”

“Hey, don’t you tease me about… *that* . I don’t know. I just- if i say it too loud, I feel like I’m sharing you with the world, a little. That’s dumb, don’t- ignore that.”

“No, no, it’s okay.” Adora has quietened back down, noticing her girlfriend’s embarrassment. “If you want, we can have a little signal.”

“A signal?”

“Yeah! Like a physical thing, that we both know means ‘I love you’.”

“So like, kissing? Adora, as much as I might want to, we can’t really just make out everywhere we go.”

“No, silly! Something subtle, that only we know means what it means. What about… oh! Three squeezes of the other’s hand. That means I love you.” Catra ponders it over. Her gut reaction is to scoff and mock, but Adora looks so damn *sincere* , and… it’s not a bad idea.

“Fine. Only because you’re actually asking me for something you want, and that’s good progress.”

“Whatever you say, *oh great* therapist Catra.” She doesn’t respond, not right away, but pushes closer into Adora’s warm body and starts purring quietly. A little while, she reaches for Adora’s hand and makes three quick squeezes in her palm. Adora looks down, and her eyes glow with such force she has to restrain the urge to transform. Instead, she just cries quietly, taking in the sight of a sleeping Catra in her lap, knowing that her last thought before accepting unconsciousness was love.

****

The ship, as it turns out, is not exactly fit for space. Adora and Catra don’t discover this right away, but halfway through their maximum speed journey to Ariabos, when it all grinds to an ear-piercing halt.

“Adora, what the *fuck* was that?”

“I think, uh- yeah, the lights have gone out.”

“Wow, really. I couldn’t tell.”

“How come you can be sarcastically annoyed with me while sitting on my lap?”

“It’s the most comfy place to be when you’re piloting the ship.”

“It makes me wanna kiss you while flying through asteroid fields. Not a good thing, Catra.”

“Well, that’s your problem, babe. Do you want me to go check the engine room?” Catra leaps out of Adora’s lap, and immediately feels a little worse.

“That would be nice. Thanks darling, love you.” Catra reaches back over to squeeze Adora’s hand before dashing away.

****

Adora is terrible at landings, apparently. Catra nearly hurls more than once on their ‘efficient’ descent to Ariabos, the rickety, taped-together ship lurching through the atmosphere with Adora straining to stay in control. They touch down on a barren expanse, following what Catra’s tracker pad informs is the highest concentration of heat signatures across the planet. They leave the ship in a hurry, basic supplies in hand, and Adora quickly slips into the now-familiar form of She-Ra, Catra suppressing a blush. They move towards the densest location for potential signs of life, a ruin off in the distance. Catra is riding on Melog in order to keep up with She-Ra’s inhuman speed, and even then lagging behind as they cross the scorched earth. The emptiness and sobering sight of destruction have made them both quiet, but when Adora stops and turns around, barely out of breath, they both smile and ignite an age-old game with wordless agreement. Competing against She-Ra is never a fair fight, but Catra does her best, and soon enough they are in the shadow of the ruin. They split off to

search, and only a few minutes later, Catra calls out to Adora. "Hey, Adora! There's something over here."

"Coming, babe." Adora picks her way through the ruins, using She-Ra to move what cannot be climbed over, mostly for fun. When she gets to Catra, standing over the gaping maw of a tunnel, there is a blush plastered on the catgirl's face. "Pleased to see me?"

"Shut up. Do you think there's something down there?"

"Well, what does the tracker pad say?"

Oh. Yeah. The tracker pad. In her gay panic, Catra had ignored the most useful thing currently in her possession. "It- uh, I'll check." The pad confirms Catra's suspicions. The tunnel, or at least whatever lies beyond it, is teeming with life. "C'mon, let's go."

"Are you sure? It looks a little… *odd* ."

"Well, I apologise to your She-Ra instincts, but it's our only lead-"

"Don't go down!" The cry comes from seemingly nowhere. They both spin around, and Catra is greeted with the bizarre sight of someone who looks very much like her.

"Right. Yeah, Catra, this planet is full of… well, people like you."

"And you didn't think that would be important information to maybe tell me?"

"It slipped my mind! And besides, it's not exactly normal for me either."

"Uh, hello? Are you two friends of Glimmer?" Adora keeps staring, in the direction of a now much closer voice, while Catra moves instinctively behind her towering form. "My name is Alei, and I'm here to help the revolution. I can take you to Glimmer and her friends."

“Why should we trust you?” Catra looks out at Alei’s slender, surreally familiar form, battered and bruised amongst the ruins.

“Well, you can’t. But I know the location of the prison that the Peacekeeping Force is being held in, and I did just stop you going down that sewer.”

“See, Catra. I knew it was weird.”

“Fine, you’re right. My tracker pad must be on the fritz.”

“Come with me.” Alei vanishes over a collapsed pillar, and Adora follows with haste. Catra frowns for a moment, stares back at the sewer, and dashes over to Adora suddenly with Melog at her side.

“We should be careful. We don’t know if this is a trap or some sort of distraction tactic.”

“I mean, we don’t have much choice, Catra. Besides, Alei doesn’t look creepy or evil. She’s just some weirdly tall catgirl, who’s clearly been through a lot during whatever the hell happened here, and wants to help *renowned hero* She-Ra. Nothing out of the norm there.”

“Sure, sure. Just, stay alert, ok?”

“Aw, are you worried about me? That is *so* embarrassing.”

“I will hit you.”

“You would *never* .”

They leave the confines of the ruins and travel across a more mountainous area that Catra presumes must have been hidden behind the more prominent remnants of the castle. In the distance is a town, clearly hit hard by the rather sobering situation on Ariabos, with a red and black flag flying overhead. “They are being held here. This is the last city held by the royalists. I can’t go in with you, I have other… missions to attend to, and I’m wanted by them, of course.” Adora nods to Alei and she parts

ways, disappearing over the crest of a hill towards a dense forest off in the distance.

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“Did you get them away?”

“Yes, your majesty. They are headed towards the fake rebel town as we speak.”

“Good work, Meora. There will be a higher place for you in my empire, when it returns to power.”

“May I ask, what happened to Alei? And why did I have to impersonate her?”

“Alei did not follow you. I have no idea where she is, other than that she is still allied with those filthy revolutionaries.”

“She- thank you, your majesty.”

“You must let go of her, Meora. That love you hold is dangerous. Snuff it out.” Meora nods and walks away, prowls the tunnels of the woodland outpost until her mind can wander freely.

You must let go.

Campfire Songs

Chapter Summary

> The Princesses (and Catra) re-tell the second half of their Ariabos mission. Adora fawns over Catra in the after-party.

Chapter Notes

> catra's arc in my head is azula -> zuko -> toph and i am 100% right.

"So, you *must* regale us your tales. If it's good enough, I'll have enough material for my next few stage productions." Double Trouble finds their way into the centre of the crowd, catching the eyes of Glimmer, Bow and Catra in order. Adora smiles gently, her arm around Catra, and moves to answer.

"Well, it wasn't all that much-"

"Are you kidding, Adora?" Bow squeals. "You and Catra were *awesome* ! Seriously, seeing you two fight together made me wish we had both of you on our side for the whole of the war. It would have been *over* for Hordak in seconds."

"I mean-"

"Oh, come on babe. We are pretty awesome. All that Horde training wasn't for nothing." Catra smirks, moving further into Adora's strong hold. Frosta, peeking out from the edge of the crowd, which has grown to fill a sizable portion of the dance hall, yells, "Adora, you and Catra should tell the whole story! Or, you know, just the parts where you punched everyone."

"We don't have to-"

"But it would be cool."

"I was getting there, Catra! Yea, ok, sure. Everyone, prepare for the greatest tale you will ever hear, a battle of wits and might, a tragedy and a triumph, a-"

"You are such an idiot."

"Our story begins in the town of- of… uhhhh-"

"And that's where I take over. Me and Adora had made it to Ariabos and been led to what we thought was a royalist town, by someone supposedly called 'Alei'. See, we had landed on the planet believing we were unnoticed, but apparently the Empress had spotted our ship in orbit and used her agents to fuck with us. So this 'Alei', who we later discovered was called Meora, takes us to this destroyed rebel-held town to get us away from the Peacekeeping thingy squad-"

"You mean the Galactic Peacekeeping Force?", Bow chirps up.

"Sure, arrow boy. So me and Adora go into this town, and it's deserted. Most of the buildings are just rubble, the tracker pads aren't showing any signs of life, and Adora's trying to use She-Ra to excavate as much of the debris as possible in case anyone survived… what happened to that place. When it starts to get dark, I get real suspicious, because why would this deserted wreck be the royalist town with a prison strong enough to hold Sparkles? Oh, and the others. Then Adora interrupts me, yelling 'I found someone!'. Of course I hurry over, and it's this little kid, all bloodied and bruised. A house had completely collapsed on his legs and Adora had to use her healing powers so he could even speak."

"So you're not gonna mention the part where you stood staring at me while I was healing instead of looking for a house with a bed, like I said?" Adora smirks and Catra goes red again in response.

"Can a girl not admire her girlfriend? Anyway, after the whole healing thing, he told us his name was Gaman and that whatever we'd been told about the town was wrong. It was a rebel hideout,

one that was supposed to be a staging post for an attack on the castle. The attack nearly worked, but the Empire retaliated, and nearly everyone in the town was murdered. Gaman survived, but saw everything, so of course the kid was really shaken up. Adora was trying to comfort him, but every time she would ask about the whereabouts of the rebels he couldn't get the words out in between tears. We got him into a bed I found in one of the few still-standing houses, and while Adora was tucking him in, I suddenly remembered something. There was a sewer that we were planning on going down back at the castle, but Meora had persuaded us away from it and towards the town. That felt *way* too suspicious after what little information Gaman had been able to give us, so I grabbed Adora and we snuck under cover of night, with Melog's cloaking illusion as extra camouflage-"

"Wait, Melog is in this story?", Huntara exclaims mid-sentence.

"Yea, they were there the whole time," replies Catra, frowning.

"Ok, well, you literally never mentioned them. Nice storytelling, Catra." Mermista's words are mostly playful, and Catra's growl in return has very little menace.

"-and we were able to make it to the castle and down the sewer."

"It smelt *awful* !"

"Babe, they know that. It's a sewer."

"I was just trying to add some of my own commentary!"

"You're such an idiot." Catra nuzzles closer into Adora's hold, which has held firm for a stunning amount of time, and returns to the story. "Adora and I split up once inside the castle to look for any kind of prison or holding cell, using the communicators we had brought from Etheria. I was starting to suspect the castle was empty, but then I heard this crashing and grunting in my left ear and of course, Adora had run into two guards while she was all She-Ra-ed up."

"I beat them, of course, but I- uh, it was quite a loud process. Catra came running in, but by that time there were alarms blaring and *loads* of guards rushing in, so now we had a whole big fight on our hands."

"It was awesome though, right? Just us two, back to back, knocking out guards left and right. Some beefy girl would come charging at us and we'd spin around so you could out-muscle her while I took on the agile ones." Frosta goes more and more wide-eyed as Catra recounts, with visible pride, her fight in the castle.

"Ohhhhhhh! This is *so cool* !"

"Frosta, weren't you there?" asks Mermista, her voice dripping with disinterest.

"Well, yea, but I was in jail with Glimmer and the others."

"Speaking of, after we had lain waste to that room full of guards, Adora and I were able to snag a map from one of their pockets and find the prison. It wasn't easy sneaking through all those ornate hallways, especially with a whole castle on high alert, but Melog here definitely helped." Catra looks down and smiles at her companion, rubbing against her and Adora's legs. "Sparkles and the gang weren't doing too great: the Empress clearly hadn't shown the most hospitality towards her guests. So Adora rips open the jail doors-"

"-Catra blushes for longer than she would ever admit, and I do some good old fancy healing magic on Scorpia and Frosta."

"For anyone wondering, it feels… fuzzy!" Scorpia pipes up, having been unusually quiet during Catra's storytelling prior to this latest interruption.

"Melog did a wonderful job of getting us all out of there under cloaking," continues Catra, choosing to ignore Adora's earlier comments, "but we quickly realised we couldn't just leave. Ariabos was in shambles, Sparkles had made some pretty stupid promises

and Adora… well, she has that damned sense of duty. So after crawling back out of the sewer, we-"

"Oh, ooh, I want to tell this part!" Glimmer yells, squeaking and clearly more than a little drunk.

"Adora, is this what she was *always* like when you met her?" murmurs Catra, half-teasing and half concerned for past-Adora's wellbeing.

"Shut up, silly. But yes. Kinda."

"Ok, so, listen up guys! This is where the story gets *real* good. Catra and Adora were being all gay and smoochy smoochy after saving us from prison, so Bow and I take charge and make up a foolproof plan to save Ariabos! Entrapta managed to rig her tracker pad to transmit a signal across the planet-"

"Well, actually, it's something I've been working on for months now because radio waves really don't cut it for long distance transmission and gravitational waves always seemed promising but I didn't have the data yet until going to Ariabos suddenly gave me…" Entrapta trails off into her own little world, and Scorpia just smiles awkwardly.

"She'll be back, just, give her a moment to ramble."

"Uhh… anyway! Entrapta's signal allowed us to rally all the inhabitants who had laid low during the fighting, 'cos Bow gave *such* a convincing message and most of them were pretty appalled by what the Empress had done. This made a whoooole new second wave of revolution that used the destruction to its advantage! Pretty sneaky, right? All across the planet, the honest, noble cat people stood up against the regime, and won! Adora and Catra snuck back into the castle to take the Empress prisoner but when they got there, she had killed herself, yada yada, that's really just the boring stuff…"

"Wait, the Empress killed herself?" Mermista is clearly shocked, her face blank. "I've read books with sudden endings but that…

you’re just gonna drop that on me?”

“Yeah, seriously?” Catra tries to look as annoyed. “You’re just gonna skip over the fact that me and Adora beat up like fifty more buff-as-hell guards to even get to the royal chambers? Sparkles, I expected better.”

“Sorry guys, it’s just not very interesting, really. She *was* a dick.”

“I mean… yeah. Still pretty *mean* , Glimmer.” Adora is frowning, and for a moment Catra wonders if she is serious. “My fighting was awesome, and you didn’t even mention it properly!”

“Ha! You are the world’s most wonderful idiot.”

“You guys are so c-”

“Bow, finish that sentence and die.”

“Guys, can we go back to the story? I still have more to say about me and Bow’s *amazing* plan-”

“No offence Glimmer, but as someone who appreciates good fiction, your storytelling sucked.”

“Hey, Mermista, that’s not very nice. I think we should be all more supportive of our friends’ interests,” says Perfuma, morphing the ballroom’s nervous energy into awkward silence. Catra takes the initiative and cuts it in two, yelling, “WHO WANTS TO GET SHITFACED!” Everyone responds with a supportive cheer, except for Adora, who pulls a sideways glance at Catra that doesn’t make up for her blushing, and Frosta, who is escorted out of the room.

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“So you didn’t really want to get ‘shitfaced’, after all?”

“Hi to you too, idiot.” Catra weaves herself into Adora’s strong, shaky hold. The night is old and warm and content, the balcony empty and open. “It wasn’t the right night. I got drunk enough

the day after we got back; don't need that experience again with even more people watching."

"But you're funny when you're drunk."

"So are you. You can barely stand right now. I'm holding you up." It's not quite true. Catra would struggle to bear all of Adora's weight without assistance, and her hold is still so firm. Adora nuzzles Catra, grinning brightly. "What are you so happy about?"

"You!"

"Happy about me?"

"You just spent hours with many people who love you very much and you loved them back. I think that's beautiful."

"Adora, you sap."

"I'm being serious! It makes me really happy, to see you grow. You're still my Catra, just… all the nice parts are there for everyone to see. It's the best story, really."

"I'm gonna kiss you now." And so they kiss. The moonlight is so comforting, and Adora's body in formal wear is so heavy that Catra thinks she might be crushed, but then at least she will know she isn't falling, because she's been crushed against something, and it is the floor of the room with the bed that holds a million memories from every life she will live, every moment she will love. She will love and love until all the lights turn on, and it is the sleepiest morning amongst history's few quiet mornings. She has fallen off the cliff and been caught, pulled back to the dances and the campfire where quiet songs will be sung to eternity. There was the night she got drunk, after the mission, and Bow was playing something badly but it never matters how you play in those moments, and Glimmer got up to dance at first which made Adora a little mad, but it was ok, she waited her turn, and Glimmer was clumsy and Catra didn't know where her legs ended but it was fun, with the clapping and the roar of the fire in the space in the woods that had welcomed a million travelers before,

whether queens or outlaws. Adora and Catra danced next. Bow played something slow, better this time. Catra drew a path down Adora's body and walked it, delved into crevices and conquered great mountains, and those were only the creases in her jacket. Parts of them both shone in the half-light, and they were always happy most of the time, at least when one saw the other's smile, that terrible, terrible smile and all the happy memories. Closed eyes and feet in unison and dance lessons with etiquette to break like china plates and the weight of galactic war never was ever an idea. I'll build you a new memory here, Adora thinks, and it'll hurt my head in the morning, but it'll be nicer than the others. This will be just like all the others, Catra thinks, but we deserve to have that many.

Catra says "I love you," by squeezing her hand three times. It echoes into the night, something other than desperation, a concrete space and a home. She does it slowly, and Adora cries for a very long time. Contemplation is linear, because Adora can only live out the feeling of love in order. It has to be this way. It's so worth it.

"It's so worth it, isn't it?"

"We're finding that out right now, forever."

"You and me, together at the end of the world. That was what we said. I really hope you never have to say that again."

"You can't prevent it."

"No, but I can still hope. That's the point."

Catra smiles, and they go to bed. Their sleep is long, and warm. Their morning is quiet. The campfire songs echo in the halls of eternity, and Catra can listen whenever she likes.

Promise Pt.2

Chapter Summary

"To think that we could stay the same
But we're two slow dancers, last ones out"
-
Mitski

Chapter Notes

and it's over!!! thank you everyone who supported this fic its been a ride

Time passes, as it does, and old age tends to happen when you least expect it. There've been friends, kind words and get well soon cards. Bow cried for two hours outside the hospital room and Adora pretended not to notice. She hugged him as hard as she could. At one point everyone was gathered in the blank, sheer white hospital room, a rare occurrence only permitted because, even in old age, you don’t argue with She-Ra. There were so many eyes full of tears, so many choked-out words and kind smiles, that Adora felt quite overwhelmed and a little tired. Adora doesn’t know how long it’s been since then; she keeps remembering in the wrong order.

The machine to her left beeps.

She doesn’t know where she was born, exactly.

Beep.

Her first memories are running through the hallways with Catra.

Beep.

She got given a whole extra ration bar by Catra for her birthday, but Shadoweaver gave her nothing.

Beep.

She’s crying in bed, but her bed is empty and that’s the damn problem. She misses the warmth on her feet.

Beep.

Her body is getting more and more bruised by Lighthope’s training sessions. Today she nearly broke a bone. She doesn’t have the strength to care.

Beep.

Catra is with her, on her ship, broken and sad and terrified but alive, beautifully alive. Adora feels warmer, heavier, fuller than she has in years. Bow says she looks happier than he’s ever seen her.

Beep.

Prime has been ended, the galactic dynasty shattered in mere moments that will echo forever. They stand in front of a new sunrise, endlessly bright and beautiful. There are no good words, just silent glory.

Beep.

And then life: sad, painful, glorious, endless, minute life occupying a perfect corner of eternity. Children and new friends and old friends no longer with them, building Etheria anew and funneling every bad dream into real, concrete happiness.

Beep.

Adora feels warm again. She can look up. It’s not over yet.

Catra is alone; she looks so small, bathing in the reflected light from a small window in the corner of the room.

“Hey, Adora.” She sees that familiar face speak those familiar words as if they were pressed together, as if Adora’s eyesight

hadn’t begun to fail so long ago.

“You’re still here.” Adora doesn’t really speak those words; she’s not sure that she can. But Catra hears.

“I was never just gonna leave you.”

The silence hangs for so long, being as it is so practiced by exploring the miles separating decades of conversation.

“I’m glad you stuck around. Didn’t want to do this part on my own, Catra.”

“It’s nothing. Not for me.”

“I did so much, Catra. I really think I did.”

Catra smiles and stands up slowly.

“Don’t worry, I know you were a great hero. This is a hero’s death, isn’t it?”

“I never wanted to be one, really.”

“But you were. I think more than that, you loved me. And by extension, everyone else.”

“Not everyone-”

“Enough for it to matter.”

“Cryptic as ever, my dear. Where are your manners for the elderly?” They both laugh, quietly, deafeningly.

“A very long time ago, you promised me something. I thought it was for everyone, just how you were. And then, slowly, I learned that I mattered, and that changed nearly everything.”

“So it’s all for the *power of love* , eh? You’re almost as cheesy as me!”

“I’m not too old for that, Adora, not too broken, not too hurt. I learnt it’s nice to remember how far you’ve come.” Adora feels compelled to say something more, though she isn’t sure where it comes from.

“I can’t promise you anything more, Catra.”

“Yes, you can.” Catra leans into the stark white bed, her face filling the image Adora had been holding in her mind this whole time. “One last dance, for us both.”

Adora barely registers twin pools collecting on her gown, how Catra’s fresh tears are starting to flow into hers.

She feels a glow, like nothing anyone has ever felt before, and though there is no transformation she is compelled to stand tall and strong.

Catra takes Adora’s hand, feels a firm grasp, and in the ancient half-light streaming through a cheap plastic window, with the smell of death and birth spiralling around them, they become the two slow dancers. Adora’s feet tread lightly on the sterile floor, her gown swaying with Catra’s body, both old and infinitely new. Everyone else has gone home. These two bodies, frail and aging, are the last ones out. Adora leads Catra in a gentle circle, the slowest dance, and remembers the sacred place of everything with the map of Catra’s body, the most sacred thing.

“This was easier before,” says Catra.

“It was never easy. We never stayed the same. But I always loved you, Catra. I always loved you.”

“I love you, forever and beyond eternity, Adora.”

They let a slow stillness fill the hospital room. Adora starts to feel the ground pulling her back down, and Catra can feel the light fading as she reaches around to grab Adora’s limp body. It’s so heavy for something so frail.

“Stay, Adora. Stay. I’m so glad you finally stayed, but do it again. Do it again. You promised! You promised!”

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